friendly
ambitious
nerd
@visakanv

friendly ambitious nerd

By Visakan Veerasamy (@visakanv)

v1.0 published 1st March 2020.

To be perfectly honest, I'm not satisfied with the current state of editing.
I underestimated how much time this project would take me.
I will be shipping v1.1 within a couple of days. If you're not in a rush to read this immediately, I recommend holding off until I get to edit it more thoroughly.
Thank you for your patience. ❤ I would also tremendously appreciate any early criticisms and requests that you might have.

This book is dedicated to every stranger who has ever been kind to me.
It is the kindness of strangers that has kept my heart aloft.

Foreward from friends

"Visa is one of the most original people I know. I don't know what he's up to. But he's up to something really special. I can confidently say there's nobody in the world like Visa. He might be the most prolific person on planet Earth." – David Perell (@david_perell), host of the North Star Podcast

"Visakan is one of the smartest men I know and manages to do it in such a kind, unpretentious "not trying to be a profound guru" sort of way. The topics he curates, then explores have on several occasions directly benefited me- either my work or just offered a better way of looking at the world." – Naomi "Sexy Cyborg" Wu (@realsexycyborg)

"Visa is that nerdy, creative friend with a magical brain who is kind enough to let you follow his musings. I have learned so much from him—it sometimes feels ridiculous to get so many brain candies for free. He helps make Twitter one of the best places to hang out and make friends. I basically see him as the cornerstone of a new kind of tribe I didn't know I needed." – Anne-Laure Le Cunff (@anthilemoon), founder of Ness Labs

introduction

Me in my parent's home office, 1998.

about me

Hello, friend!

My name is Visakan Veerasamy. I go by @visakanv all over the Internet, and my friends call me Visa. I was born in Singapore in 1990. I was a bookish child who loved libraries, and when I discovered the Internet, I fell in love with it too. A library I could contribute directly to! A home of my own, in cyberspace! I was bewitched.

I was obsessed with video game forums and bulletin boards, and when I started playing in bands, I became obsessed with MySpace and music forums. I went on to spend lots of time on LiveJournal, and Quora, and Reddit, and Facebook. I recently joked to a friend that "The Internet is my mom," and on retrospect there's really a lot of truth in that statement.

In June 2018, I left my job in software marketing to focus on writing for pleasure as much as I could, everywhere. Since then, My Twitter following exploded from under 2,000 to over 19,000 followers, and I started receiving all sorts of positive and encouraging comments. "You should write a book, I'd read it," was something I'd hear fairly often. So here we are. I've thought long and hard about what my first offering should be, and I've decided that *FRIENDLY AMBITIOUS NERD* is the best frame for it.

What's the point of this book?

"Never doubt that a small group of thoughtful, committed citizens can change the world; indeed, it's the only thing that ever has." – Margaret Mead

"You all have a little bit of 'I want to save the world' in you, that's why you're here, in college. I want you to know that it's okay if you only save one person, and it's okay if that person is you." – tahtahtahlia's anthropology professor

I'm writing this because I want to encourage you to become a friendlier, nerdier and more ambitious person.

I believe that doing this has dramatically improved my quality of life, and I believe that this is something that anybody can do for themselves, too.

Over the years, I've helped dozens, maybe hundreds of other people along on their personal journeys. I'm writing this to share the essence of many of those conversations – hopefully it'll be of some help to you, and if it is, hopefully you'll then be able to go and help someone else in turn.

My goal: by the time you're done with this book, you will be persuaded that you could be doing more to become a more nourishing presence in the world, and that it's worth doing.

For others, yes. And also for yourself.

(And it won't be some tedious, burdensome obligation, either. It'll be *fun*. I promise!)

PS: I highly encourage you to talk about this book with others! Take screenshots, post them on social media, @-mention me! Let's talk :)

1-page summary of the whole book

FRIENDLINESS is about being a nourishing presence. It's about becoming somebody who people (including yourself!) love and enjoy. It's about creating supportive, encouraging spaces where people can feel comfortable sharing their honest feelings. Humans are a social species, we're practically wired to desire kinship, to be a part of something bigger than ourselves. So why not get good at it? To be a great friend, I believe that it's necessary to learn to address your own neediness and insecurities, and to cultivate an abundance mindset in relation to other people. Learn to give sincere compliments, to be a gracious host, to be artful in conversation, to always be a cherished asset in any social space you inhabit.

AMBITION is about daring to dream bigger. It's about realizing that you can live a much "larger" life. Ambition is often framed as the desire for power and prestige. I prefer to frame it as something more intimate. Ambition to me is about wanting to do more, be more, see more, learn more, know more. It's about recognizing that your own imagination is a bottleneck that limits the amount of good you can create in the world. Untethered ambition by itself can be a dangerous thing, but if you temper your ambition with good taste and ground it with a sensitivity to others, I believe it can be a force for tremendous good.

NERDINESS is about cultivating taste and curiosity. It's about developing the courage to be honest with yourself about what you find interesting. A lot of what is beautiful in the world was made by nerds – music, technology, science, movies, books, you name it. It's a fundamentally nerdy thing to decide to sit down and spend years of your life exploring your interests. Doing this is a joy in itself, and it's also a great gift that you can give to others. To be a nerd is to liberate yourself from over-preemptively worrying about what other people think. By doing the nerd's work, you will develop a healthy, rigorous and honest regard for your own opinions. You'll find, delightfully, that others start valuing your thoughts more, too!

Navigation

friendly ambitious nerd **1**

introduction **3**

about me 4

What's the point of this book? 5

1-page summary of the whole book 6

friendship **9**

the helm of the arse gods 10

the meaning of life is friends 12

be friends with yourself 13

Attention is powerful social currency 14

feel your feelings 17

Empty your cup 19

being smart vs being kind 21

a table of my own 25

Being nice vs being kind 27

We can take turns 27

Being "yourself" 28

Practice good reply game 29

Asking good questions 30

Giving specific and sincere compliments 32

Parents, peers and other benevolent plagues 33

The creation and maintenance of scenes 38

Marriage and romantic relationships 41

Flirting and playfulness 54

The shadow world of social reality 56

Managing disagreements requires context-sensitivity 57

What makes a disagreement interesting? 62

Dealing with assholes 64

Dealing with contempt 66

Questions for communities 68

Safe spaces are for nurturing, not coddling 69

Ambition **72**
Ambition is not about accolades 73
Imagination deficits rule everything around me 75
Be so prolific you don't recognize yourself 76
Always be seeking new friends 77
You can't think your way out of a courage deficit 79
Be wary of hotheads 80

Nerd **81**
Consider our nerdy predecessors 82
I was raised by libraries 83
Take notes 84
Cultivate and gratify your taste 86
FAQs about taste 89
Be Precise 91
How I deal with my ADHD 92
Pay It Forward 96

Closing thoughts **99**

Acknowledgements **100**

friendship

Me and my bandmate Adnin in 2007, hanging out before one of our band's gigs.

the helm of the arse gods

One of my first life-shaping experiences on the Internet was when I lied on a video game forum. The game was Darkstone, a somewhat obscure Diablo-style RPG that was released in 1999 by a small French team called Delphine Software. I persuaded my mum to buy me the game at a bookstore, and I was delighted to discover that there was an Internet forum where Darkstone players could talk with each other about the game. None of my friends played it, but these Internet strangers did!

I don't even really remember the specifics of what I talked about with people. I think I was just so happy to *participate* that I didn't give any thought to what I was saying. One day, somebody joked in a thread that they got a rare magical helmet called the "Helm of the Arse Gods". His sarcasm must have been obvious to everyone else, but being a clueless kid eager to impress others, I lied and said I got it too. I was like… 10. Everyone cringed and laughed at me.

The embarrassment and shame I felt made me determined to be "good at Interneting". I went on to participate in all sorts of forums, and I would study the social dynamics and conflicts closely. I would learn how social points are scored. I got a deep pleasure from being a "respected user" of a bunch of communities.

To me it became a game. I started to believe that every community could be "cracked". I became a three-time Quora Top Writer. I got a blogpost to the front page of Hacker News. I even have a couple of mod-issued Points on /r/theredpill. I became a "sociopolitical blogger" in the local news.

When I say "game", though, I don't mean it in a dismissive way. I took it all very seriously and spent lots of time and energy on it. I was especially determined to avoid faking or lying, since that's what got me in trouble in the first place. Rather, I taught myself how to present a genuine version of myself that's compelling to people.

In 2012, I was invited to speak with Singapore's Prime Minister, Lee Hsien Loong. I've also openly criticised the Singapore Government's policies on several occasions, and even had those views published in the "government mouthpiece media" — because I knew how to frame it. So sometimes I feel like I have superpowers, because it seems like I'm able to do things that other people say isn't possible.

But really, all of these are skills that I picked up in order to impress video game nerds.

So if you're reading this, I think it's fair to say that we can both thank The Helm Of The Arse Gods for bringing us here. What a strange world we live in.

the meaning of life is friends

A scene from Somebody Feed Phil.

“Make friends” is maybe the simplest two word directive in my memespace that has the most influence on everything else. To make good friends you have to be kind, interesting, sensitive, ethical. If not for the nourishment of friendship I would probably be a selfish asshole.

Getting better at socialising is possibly the single best thing anybody can do. It’ll upgrade your social graph, open doors, make you a better husband, lover, son, brother, dad, friend, boss, coworker, pal, rival.

We are social creatures, and might as well get good at it.

Somebody Feed Phil is possibly my favourite show on Netflix. It’s so heartening and wholesome, this guy just going around the world & eating beautiful food with kind, warm-hearted, funny, lovable people. The food is a head-fake; the whole point - the meaning of life - is friends.

be friends with yourself

The most important person you have to be friends with is yourself.

Much of self-improvement, personal development, introspection and so on can quite simply be reframed as the art of socialising with yourself.

Listen to yourself, pay close attention to yourself, don't interrupt yourself, be kind and supportive to yourself, be constructive in criticism

I believe that there's a "strange loop" between private and social life. Many people are dicks to themselves because others were dicks to them in ways they did not even fully appreciate. They then go on to be dicks to others, and the cycle continues. We can actually refuse to participate in this cycle.

People can tell if you don't have a good relationship with yourself. And it's very difficult to have good relationships with others if you don't have a good relationship with yourself.

This, of course, shouldn't become something else that you beat yourself up over. That's the whole problem. I find that it helps to try and have a sense of humor about it. If you can laugh, you can crack the solemnity that traps you in "woe is me".

Incidentally, self-loathing is totally a form of narcissism. Because when you hate yourself, there's a part being hated, and there's another part doing the hating. The hater self is often conveniently behind the curtain, free from the scrutiny that they impose on the rest of themselves.

Attention is powerful social currency

I believe that, as social creatures, kinship is the most important thing in life. Everything else is downstream of great relationships. No matter how hard we try to resist it, the gravitational pull of our peers is inescapable. We end up thinking like our peers.

And I think that possibly the most important thing in a relationship – including one with yourself, or your spouse, or your child - is attention. Deep, focused, undivided, non-judgemental attention.

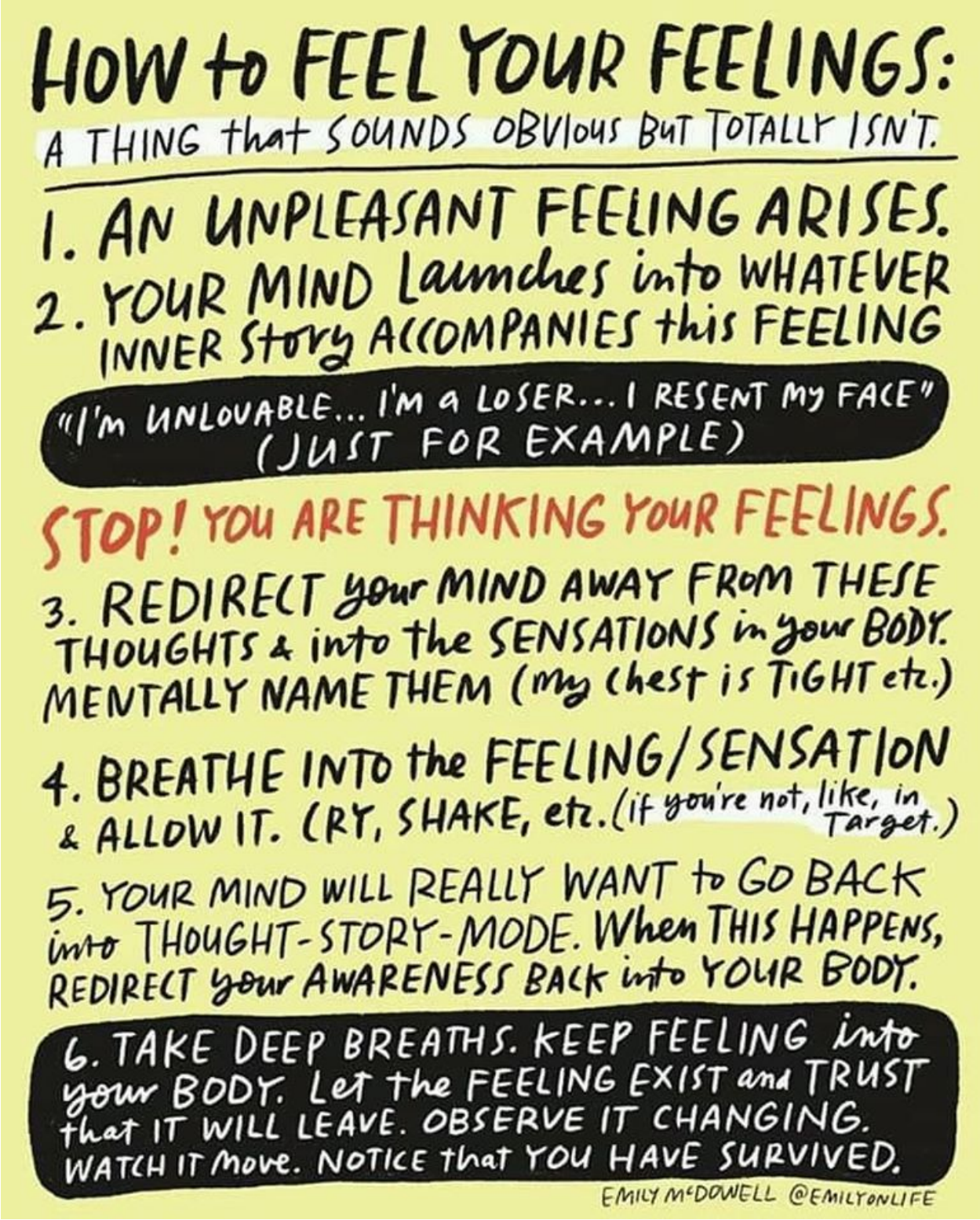
To really see and hear the other person, in a world where people constantly feel unseen & unheard.

Now, If the most important thing about the most important thing in life is attention– how are we teaching people to think about it?

In school, we're always telling kids to "pay" attention. And I think it's accurate to say that we effectively use threats and coercion to force kids to "pay" attention. And this in turn, I believe, sets people up for dysfunctional relationships their whole life.

We all want attention. Maybe different people want it to different degrees, and maybe it's true that some subset of people seek obnoxious amounts of it because of some sort of dysfunction or addiction. But it's like having an eating disorder – it doesn't change the fact that you still have to eat. As social creatures it's inescapable. We might as well get good at managing it well.

feel your feelings



Originally a Tinyletter.

Oh man, I have a lot of feelings. I have feelings about my feelings. When I was growing up as a kid, nobody really talked about feelings. My family didn't particularly talk about feelings, although I noticed when people were angry or upset. But we didn't talk about that. I don't recall school talking about feelings. It's really interesting to reflect back on. Most of what I knew or thought about feelings, I got from books, from games, from music, from art. Maybe a part of it is a *~traditional masculinity~* thing – boys don't talk about their feelings. Maybe part of it is an Asian thing, Singaporeans don't really talk about their feelings either. I don't know. I feel like the guy from Memento, trying to piece things together.

I find myself thinking, when I was a teenager, I don't think I cared about feelings? Or I thought that I didn't care about feelings. It's complicated. There was a denial aspect to it. I thought that I had to be some sort of happy-go-lucky, unaffected, blissful joker. And I believed sincerely that that was who I was. And so... when I got anxious at school, I didn't entirely notice it. Does that make sense? I'm realizing on retrospect that I actually know what denial is like, because I was in denial about my feelings a lot of the time. And, obviously, if anybody had said to me "you're in denial about your feelings", I'd probably have laughed them off.

I *did* play in a rock band and write songs, so I did know what it was to be emotive, to be passionate. I *was* writing and introspecting on Livejournal. I do remember writing emo poetry, and long, sad, morose blogposts to my friends. So it's not like I was entirely cold, or entirely fake-happy. I'm scrolling through some of those old blogposts now and... it was... clunky? Dramatic? There is some complexity and nuance here that I'm not entirely appreciating.

The thought + feeling + experience I've been having more and more lately is – "I spend really little time in my body". Like, I'm always in my head, I'm always somewhere else, I'm always thinking about something, I'm always... somewhere else. And I guess after years of working, I've gotten stiff in some ways, and not just physically. There are feelings that bubble up when I'm really present and

stretching. I don't know if these are feelings that I had forgotten to properly feel when I was younger. Am I leaning a little too hard into the whole trauma body idea? I don't know. It's messy. I'm figuring it out.

Empty your cup

I never really understood the whole “empty your cup” and “unlearn what you have learned” thing until maybe a couple of years ago. Like, intellectually it sorta made sense, but… is it really that big a deal?

I’ve come to think that it actually is. How did I learn how to see it?

I think it might‘ve been a consequence of being exposed to a much larger number of people and having lots of conversations – over time I noticed that some people were bringing all their baggage to every conversation, while others were listening intently.

“Never be looking so hard for something that you fail to see what is there” – there’s a quote like this and I’ve seen people retweet saying “ah it’s about journalism” and others saying “ah it’s about scientific discovery” and “ah it’s about parenting”… It’s about life, silly!

If you start looking for it there are tonnes of gems throughout the history of art and culture and storytelling that try to convey this. In *The Dark Knight Returns*, Batman couldn't make the leap until he let go of the rope. It's really a metaphor for letting go, more broadly, in general.

We can probably graph this in some way. When we're holding on to preexisting ideas about what we're looking for, who we're talking to, etc – there's a sort of Procrustean effect that takes place. We mostly only see what we're looking for. It makes us slow, stupid. We fail to notice nuance, surprise.

We might *feel* fast and smart, but we're only fast and smart within the narrow bounds of the game that we think we're playing. When we are fixated on the game we think we're playing, we close ourselves off from playing a bigger, better, more interesting game.

Circling back to "active listening" – that's another thing that sounded dumb to me. I hear what you're saying, why do I have to be all… wooey… about it? But I've grown to realize that words they say are like ~20% of what's being communicated

The best questions you can ask someone is in that space where you're paying close attention to them – to their face, their expressions, their body language, and you notice that they're holding back in some way. They might not even realize themselves that they're doing that!

This is true for regular conversation too, and I think it's true of comedy, wit, and of business – IMO I almost always want to be willing + able to drop my current routine/pattern instantly in order to respond quickly and nimbly to what's in front of me

At the heart of this, I think, is a question: **do we allow life to surprise us?** Bc everything we think we know is a *tiny* fragment of the world. The world *will* surprise us, in both good & bad ways. Emptying your cup is about refusing to be in denial.

being smart vs being kind

When I was a child, I was told that I was smart. I wasn't great at socializing, but I was alright. I was the class clown, the smartass, so I did have some friends. But I never really developed the deep, lasting sort of friendships that some people have for life.

Sometimes I felt like I was missing out, but most of the time – even now – I think of it as, 'that's just what life is like for misfits'. There's good and bad, and that's the 'bad'. The price you pay.

It took me two decades to really begin to aspire to be kind.

What's so good about being smart?

1. There is a certain intrinsic pleasure to knowing things. Richard Feynman describes this beautifully in "the pleasure of finding things out". (He was also a very kind person, I believe.)

2. There's a practical value to it. Smartness is generally correlated with making good decisions that lead to superior outcomes. (It's necessary but insufficient – smartness is the sharpness of the knife. You still need to handle the knife well, and apply it to the right things. Lots of smart people obsessively sharpen their knives but don't use it for anything useful or constructive.)

If you're smart, in the conventional sense, you should recognize opportunities (in my view this requires sensitivity, in the 'perceptive' sense) and take advantage of them (in my view this requires strength, in the 'executive' sense). You should also spot potholes and avoid them. (Spotting the pothole is perception. Avoiding it is execution. Smartness is the gap between seeing and doing – smartness is orienting and deciding, maybe.)

3. There's also a social aspect to smartness. I'm not saying that smartness guarantees social success (though I do believe that if you're truly smart rather than superficially smart, you'll figure out how to achieve your social desires and/or modulate them appropriately).

What I mean is that there's a sort of global subculture that venerates smartness. Think of all the tropes of trickster type characters, and how people love brilliant assholes like Tony Stark and Dr. House. If you're smart, you can satisfy quite a lot of your social needs by scoring points with smartness geeks.

The smartness-as-spectator-sport trap

Here's where it gets a little dicey: winning friends in most smartness tribes – their approval requires being right. It requires Winning. I'm talking about smartness as a contact sport for spectators. You get rewarded for the most brutal takedowns ("Liberal DESTROYED conservative with simple argument, leaves him SPEECHLESS!")

When you start to get addicted to winning, you start to get attached. You start to avoid certain things – particularly areas that you're not so sure about. You start picking your battles according to what's winnable, rather than what's most interesting or useful.

This is where we get to what separates the pros from the noobs. The smartest people embrace their ignorance. They are intimately familiar with the limitations of their models, and they are excited when they discover that they're wrong about something. (I recall this book about physics – "Time, Space and Things" – where the author would spend paragraphs explaining the imperfections of all the models he was about to show us. It was lovely.)

Where does kindness enter the picture? Kindness nourishes (not coddles) fragile things and makes them strong.

I find myself thinking about Pixar's Braintrust. It's a sort of council of storytellers who provide advice and support to whoever's working on a story. They understand that ideas in their formative stages are precious, fragile things, like babies. You can't shake them too hard at the start, or they'll die. You need to nourish them and let them flourish first. You need to ask lots of exploratory questions with good-faith, rather than cross-examine them looking for flaws and mistakes. Once it's found its legs, THEN you can start to challenge it, spar with it, and it'll grow stronger as a result.

When I was younger, I truly believed that the best way to learn and grow and progress was to subject everything to relentless scrutiny. To debate, argue, attack from all sides. I still believe that that can be true in some cases, and that individuals who are deeply committed to learning and intellectual development can benefit tremendously from welcoming such behavior. Inviting criticisms and takedowns. Soliciting negative feedback.

BUT, I've also grown to learn that there's this whole other side to the picture. What you see is NOT all there is. There's a lot that you haven't seen, that you can't see – and if you saw it with an open mind, you'd almost definitely revise your model of reality.

In the past, I used to argue violently with everything and everyone. Not in a vicious way, just in a high-contact way. It was a sport, it was a way of life. With every fight, I was learning. (In retrospect, I was often just learning how to fight better, or to pick fights where I'd have a higher probability of winning, but that seemed like progress at the time.)

I lost some friends along the way, which I was sad about. But I usually found a way to live with it – mostly by convincing myself that they had in some way been too sensitive.

I had a Kurt Cobain quote in mind – "Better to be hated for who you are than loved for who you're not". It seemed radically profound at the time, but on hindsight, that's entire oversimplistic thinking. We have more than two options. (When I first wrote this, I was the same age that Kurt Cobain was when he died. As I edit this, I'm now I'll be older than he'll ever be. Just a thought.)

Here's what you miss if you're unkind or non-kind: people opening up to you in private. A lot of the most interesting information in the world is locked up inside other people's heads.

If you care about having an interesting life, you have to care about winning over other people – even if only so that you can access that information. If you really want to be smart, you're going to have to tap into people's perspectives, insights, questions and so on. You can't learn it all from books and essays – because there's a lot of "living knowledge" that never makes it into those things.

People only started opening up to me in private in the last 3-5 years or so, and it's completely changed my life. I mean, I did have conversations with a handful of close-ish friends a decade ago, but now I have people actively coming to me and telling me things that they wouldn't dare say publicly. And that's some very powerful, very interesting stuff. It's great at many levels. And it's a very beautiful feeling to be that person that earns other people's trust.

It's possible to be both smart and kind, obviously. That's the end goal. Being smart doesn't mean you're going to be kind, not-kind or unkind. Being kind doesn't mean you're going to be smart, not-smart or stupid.

What I'm saying is – there's definitely a subset of smart people (and people who aspire to smartness) who think that being kind is unnecessary, or tedious, or for pussies, and so on. And I think that's extremely unfortunate. Your intelligence gets enriched by kindness. That's the case I'm making here.

a table of my own

In April/May of 2019, Twitter friends from San Francisco paid for me to get on a plane and fly across the world to meet them in person. They made me feel so welcome, so loved, so appreciated. It felt like a “Cinderella ball” moment for me, it was truly a transformative experience for me, and one of the happiest moments of my life. To explain this, I have to tell my story about tables.

Have you ever instantly developed a deep admiration for somebody for who they are as a person? I last felt this way about Barack Obama (even if we completely exclude his Presidency!), and I feel similarly about Bozoma Saint John, who was formerly the Chief Brand Officer at Uber. Her story is remarkable to me.

Bozoma was born in Connecticut to Ghanaian parents. She grew up moving frequently, including to Ghana and Kenya, before settling down in Colorado. She was obviously Not White, but she was also not quite African-American, and not quite African. A foreigner everywhere.

I feel this.

(My personal lil' version of this, for comparison. I was born in Singapore to a Tamil family. I'm a minority here. My Tamil is pretty terrible, so I'm an outsider within the Tamil community. Indians from India typically think of me as a Singaporean. Elsewhere, people assume I'm Indian.)

Bozoma's life story reminds me of Obama's, and punches through my heart in the same way. These funny-colored kids with funny-sounding names, casually ostracized for being different, diving deep into the culture of their peers to understand them better than they know themselves.

"I don't know if I'm ever considered a part of the community I'm in. I think I've always felt an outsider, in both places, everywhere." – *Bozoma*

In my own life, I have taught myself so much about Singaporean history, Chinese culture, American pop culture. Lately I've been reading up about Indian history and pop culture, too. Because there is no table at the cafeteria for kids who look and sound like us. We have to earn our seats.

Obama still blows my mind, too. A non-Hawaiian in Hawaii. A non-Indonesian in Indonesia. A Christian with a Muslim name. A half-Black dude in white society. A half-White guy in black society. No in-group. No table at the cafeteria. No way to blend in, no archetype to follow.

We can take turns

"Sing us a song /
And we'll sing it back to you /
We could sing our own /
But what would it be without you?"
– Paramore, My Heart

In the early days, humans supposedly stored food surplus “in each other's stomachs” – I can't eat the whole deer I just hunted, so I share my deer with you today, you share your deer with me tomorrow. That way we both get to eat, and excess meat doesn’t go to waste.

I think something similar is true when talking about dealing with all sorts of difficulty. We don’t have to go it alone. None of us needs to be happy, well-adjusted, mature, enlightened, etc all the time.

We can *take turns*. We can take care of each other. We can sooth and comfort and challenge each other, lift each other up.

I think school disincentivizes this. School indoctrinates kids to compete with each other on standardized tests, to see others as competitors rather than potential collaborators. this atomizes people, makes them feel isolated, disconnected, fearful of not measuring up, jealous of others' successes.

Sometimes you get people asking, "how do you compete with smarter people?" I find myself instead asking, "How do you win the love, trust, support & goodwill of smarter people, so that THEY are on YOUR side?" I think it’s a far more interesting and exciting question.

Practice good reply game

There is an art to replying and commenting, and probably like 60-70% of people I've seen on the internet seem to fail at it. The important thing is not to speak your mind, but to "support" the person you're replying to. You can support them by disagreeing well, and you can "mis-support" them by agreeing poorly.

Every "utterance" (status, tweet, whatever) is a bit of an invitation, a bit of a proposal. "Let's play this game". When strangers read the proposal accurately, and support the game, a shared understanding develops. You can make friends this way.

Some people deliberately choose to ignore, misread, disregard or denounce other people's bids. Others are outright clueless and don't know how to play, and sometimes cluelessness leads to worse bungling than deliberate malice (JJ's razor: "The intentionality of an agent with behavior sufficiently indistinguishable from malice, is irrelevant.")

I was a lot more belligerent and disagreeable when I was younger, in part because I simplistically thought playing other people's games was a sheep-like way to live. Why should I support other people's dumb games? Why not mock them instead? It's easy, and intoxicating.

We can't choose where we are born, or our family, and our initial set of friends is heavily influenced by happenstance. But we can choose who we want to be associated with subsequently. All problems are interpersonal problems, but we kind of get to choose which ones we want.

Many different lines of enquiry have led me to this same conviction:

The best guiding question in life is, "Who do you want to share this life with?"

Everything else can be derived from this question. Your ethics, beliefs, actions, habits.

Asking good questions

Zane Lowe is one of the best interviewers I have ever seen. Several of his interviewees end up crying during his interviews, to their own surprise.

"The best advice is not to tell people what to do, but to ask them the right questions. Find out what's going on in their head, and help them frame that in a way that's useful." – David Allen, aka @gtdguy

When it comes to interviews, conversations and flirting, the most powerful isn't asking good questions nearly as much as asking good followup questions - it's being sensitive to interesting micro-reactions. When you ask a question and they respond "Ha... no", and you go "Why'd you laugh?"

This is the script of no script, the formula of no formula, you just pay really close attention to the other person in a curious, non-judgmental way without the burden of expectations, and look for anything surprising or interesting - and ask about that in a supportive way.

If you do this well, over the course of a conversation you'll end up asking questions that make them go "huh, nobody's asked me that before" and "I've never really thought of that", and that often ends up being quite a bonding experience.

Little things like "you hesitated for a moment there, why?" can unearth things you won't believe.But you have to do it in a very kind, nurturing and gentle way, or people will get defensive. You want to be so curious about people that you make them freshly curious about themselves.

My ex-boss gave me this gift. He was more curious about me than I was about myself. He genuinely wanted to understand my motivations & backstory to a degree that I had stopped caring about, because I didn't think I merited that much concern. a lot of what I do now is pass that on.

Everybody needs this, but nobody needs it more than kids. Kids are so used to being pushed around, told what to do, being treated as incomplete humans on probation. Give kids your sincere, attentive curiosity and you will change their lives forever.

Also, kids are fascinating! Particularly because they haven't been fully socialized yet. They each still have some weirdness and oddness in them unique to themselves. It's quite inspiring and humbling to witness if you can.

Thinking more, I realize this is about paying attention to people's physiological responses & being supportively curious about that. Why did you cringe, why did you flinch? Why did you frown, shudder, laugh, scoff? The body keeps the score. IRL still trumps URL here.

All of that said, if you need a starting question to surface and unearth responses to ask further about, “what is your relationship with X” is my favorite. What is your relationship with fitness? With food? With the internet? Then observe closely.

What is the history of your relationship with music? With travel? With leadership? With taking responsibility? Strength? Vulnerability? Fashion? Self-expression? Optimism? Being a public figure? Privacy? Intimacy? Ugh, I am so curious about everything and everyone!! 😂😅🤓❤️

Giving specific and sincere compliments

I don’t know if I ever specifically set out to learn this, but I’ve gotten pretty good at it over the years: I think giving people specific and sincere compliments is a pretty great skill to develop. It’s at the intersection of making people feel good + developing your taste.

The simplest way to do this without even getting specific is saying something like “this is particularly good!” - whether your friend is posting hot takes or makeup selfies, some will be better than others. Identifying that and pointing it out is an act of service.

In recent times I have complimented people on...

- rad colourful leggings
- cool red leather jacket

- cool nose ring
- evil looking locket that made her look like a powerful witch (she's a fantasy writer, I knew she'd appreciate it)

Importantly, these are all things I sincerely thought were cool.

Getting specific is where the magic is though. For example, if you're responding to a creative, they'll appreciate it if you mention specific bits that you thought were particularly interesting or good. It helps them level up! It's a great little gift.

A fantastic bonus to this is that you start to become more attentive over time. You become more discerning, you develop good taste. And if you make sure to be honest, people will start coming to you for your input, because they trust that you will be honest, and they also trust that you will be kind. It's a great place to be.

Parents, peers and other benevolent plagues

I've been reflecting on how people get into drinking and smoking and drugs. And by extension, how my life has come along so far.

Unintended damage caused by protective parents and authorities

When you're a kid, every parent and teacher and authority will, understandably, tell you what you cannot do, what your boundaries are, what you must or must not do.

They will also lie to you or deceive you about a bunch of things– religion, sex, drugs, alcohol, poverty, death and so on. They do this partially to protect you from the ugly, messiness of reality, and partially to save themselves a lot of grief.

They might have set out with the intention of answering all your questions and telling you the truth of everything, but the reality of parenting is difficult and painful and nobody can do a perfect job. (Louis CK and Michael McIntyre have covered this reality humorously.)

A part of them wants to make sure you don't get hurt. A part of them even wants to keep you cute, simple, helpless. (Paul Graham has written about this really nicely with Lies We Tell Kids).

When you first discover this, it's easy to get angry with your parents about this. But as you grow older and begin to have responsibilities and obligations of your own [2], you realize that adulthood is a lot harder than childhood, and that parenthood must be even harder.

So you sympathize with them– or if they were really, really messed up, at best you might understand why they were the way they were, even if you can never quite forgive them. Acceptance is a worthy thing to work towards.

The seductive peers and the (often misleading) promise of escape

In contrast to all of that, the first person who offers you your first cigarette or drink tends to appeal to your independence. They'll ask, "Why are you worried about what other people think?" It's a question you might not have even thought to ask until that point.

And they're usually really sweet in those moments. They'll look into your eyes and treat you like a full person, a full adult, not a child, not an obligation. They seem sincerely interested in you, your struggles, your concerns.

It is INCREDIBLY flattering. It goes beyond "Wow, you're pretty." It's more like "Wow, you're YOU."

And so I think when people say yes to cigarettes, to unprotected sex, to staying out late, THAT'S what they're saying yes to. Every kid knows cigarettes are disgusting. We do scary, dangerous and unfamiliar things because for the first time it seems like someone truly cares about us- not just our grades or our health or the labels on the pedestals they put us on.

Some people dismiss all of this as childish rebellion- and yes, it is. But it's so much more than that, too. It's a naive, ignorant and tentative step towards independence. When do you learn who you are otherwise? When do you learn to live for yourself?

Owning a decision is a powerful, heady thing, even if it's a really stupid decision. Tattoos, piercings, boyfriends, whatever. "I will what I want."

Moving forward: encourage self-exploration and self-determination in yourself and others

If all of this is true then we can imagine what the healthier alternative must be like. When adults treat children like people, with their own minds and interests and curiosities. Encouraging them to explore their OWN interests, not just what Daddy wishes he was good at as a child. The parent or authority's job isn't to decide for the child outright, but to provide an environment and context in which the child can explore and learn and grow.

And here a bunch of nice pictures come into my mind.

Kahlil Gibran's poetry: "Your children are not your children / They are the sons and daughters of Life's longing for itself."

A Truly Great teacher who really cares– the teachers that everybody remembers their whole lives. A football coach and his heartfelt pep talk. That darkroom scene

in Boyhood with the photography teacher. Robin Williams in Good Will Hunting and Dead Poet's Society.

If you have a young person in your life, pay full attention to them and ask them what they're interested in. And it's genuinely interesting! Every person is a glorious kaleidoscope of curiosities, shaped by unique perceptions and perspectives. You'll see the universe in their eyes.

And the scary, terrible thing is that these things can be really fragile. A few dismissive sentences can crush it outright. (See: ZenPencils: Kevin Smith — It costs nothing to encourage an artist)

So you have to be really gentle with people's dreams. Never tell them that they're stupid or wrong. Just ask them if they've thought about X, if they've thought about Y, and so on.

AND really, this applies just as much to adults too, just that we tend to take a little longer because we've often internalized a lot of BS over the years and we forget what we care about.

So, what do YOU want to do with this precious, fleeting life?

---

[2] I have come to believe that it's important to introduce children to responsibilities and obligations as early as possible. And it's very important to be precise here– it can't just be arbitrary things that parents impose on children "to teach them lessons". Kids tend to know when adults are simply lording over them. The challenge is to help the kids pick responsibilities and obligations that THEY want, because it helps THEM achieve what THEY want.

I'm naive and ignorant here as a non-parent, but I think even things like household chores could and should be framed in the child's self-interest rather than just "DO AS I SAY." After all, there's a real relationship between parent and child, isn't there? If the child helps the parent do something, the parent is freed up to do something else, aren't they? So can't the parent frame this trade as something ultimately beneficial to the child? But of course, Louis CK and Michael Mcintyre have pointed out that I'm an idiot for thinking that it might be so doable.

[3] One of the painful parts of growing out of adolescence is realizing that that too is an illusion. That the tantalizing promise of escape is often just a new set of blinders and chains. That's the truth that our parents and teachers learned and try to share with us, but it's hard to see that. So I think stories and movies that communicate this effectively are really important. It will be good if this were a part of our broader cultural understanding, something that we appreciated as true independent of our relationships with our parents and authority figures.

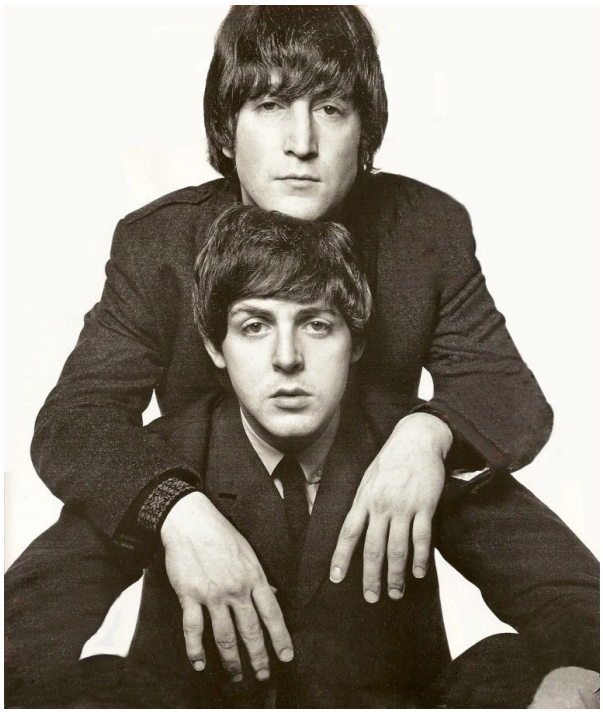
Here now I find myself thinking about Frozen, where Anna falls for Hans, but it turns out that Hans really just wanted the kingdom and didn't care about her at all. I think we all know what it's like to be used by somebody that we thought actually cared about us. Of course, reality is rarely so black and white– we're all using each other to some degree, the question is is the outcome mutually beneficial, or is it exploitative and destructive?

[4] As we get older it becomes clearer that a lot of youthful interests are driven by peer influence. And that's quite rational, isn't it? You're going to live amongst your peers, so we're wired to inherit the group's interests. It's only a while later that you learn that it probably makes sense to find out who you are outside of the group that you probably inherited rather than chose.

There's a lot to dig into here. We don't often choose our peer groups very deliberately– they're usually chosen for us by circumstance, and we tend to be compelled to stick with them because of "loyalty" or some other instinct or social pressure. One of the best things we can do for ourselves is to be deliberate about

the peers we associate with. Again I think parents try to teach their kids this, but they probably often do it in an overly dictated way– you don't want to choose for your kids outright, you want to ask them what they want out of life and what sort of friends they think they ought to hang out with.

The creation and maintenance of scenes



Here's one of my recurring talking points that I rant about to anybody who's willing to listen:

Any small group of people loosely-but-truly aligned on something can create powerful vectors by producing public-facing work that's directed at each other.

I'm talking about the creation of scenes, basically.

A lot of scenes falter because the alignment isn't sufficiently "true", and because there aren't enough good people who know how to hold it together.

This is my unhappy assessment of the problem with many arts scenes. Music & literature scenes seem to be full of people who care about neither music & literature.

What's a minimum viable scene? If you have two sufficiently obsessive people who are trying to impress and outdo each other in public, two is enough. But usually it seems that it takes a wider scene to generate 2 such obsessive people.

In reality, scenes seem to need like maybe around 2 dozen people. You need the conflict and collaboration and one-upmanship to push people far out of homeostasis.

I beat this drum periodically to find the others. A sad thing is that there don't actually seem to be very many others. Few people have any real creative vision, any real ambition. I'm not trying to be mean, it's just true. But there's a reason to stay optimistic nevertheless: we only need a few people.

An additional confounding factor: Not only do most people not have any real creative vision or ambition... many people entertain themselves by PRETENDING that they do.

Most people want their lives to be sitcoms that pretend to be adventures. But if you can make the leap and decide that you're an adventurer... and then, by going on small adventures, find the other adventurers, then you can pool your energies and resources and go on BIG adventures.

I always suspected this to be true, and my knowledge of it has grown.

It's interesting to reflect on how my frustration has shifted over the years. I used to be frustrated that people didn't care (why don't Singaporeans support local music?!?!). Then I got frustrated that artists didn't care (why are local musicians

quibbling over dumb shit?!?) But now I realize the only thing that matters is finding True Artists and supporting and challenging them, and the bottleneck there is my own thinking, my own behavior.

Marriage and romantic relationships

The day I married @sharanvkaur, 10 Dec 2012. ❤

The following is a cleaned up summary of five of my Twitter threads that surprised me with how popular they were. I guess people are eager to read and think about relationships.

1. There are reliable indicators that predict relationship failure

My wife predicts divorces and failed relationships with stunning accuracy and I have learned a few of her tricks.

Relationships are fucking hard, and to work they need a sort of functional "economy" (gratitude, laughter, kindness) and waste elimination system (pain, resentment).

Relationships typically fail either because the economy died (no happiness) or the trash pileup in the street made it inhabitable (too miserable to function). Both have symptoms & warning signs you can look out for.

Just as how "the score takes care of itself", there are some fundamental, structural things that need to exist in order to manage a relationship's economy. These are the equivalent of things like rule of law and a reliable money supply. It's especially necessary for weathering inevitable disasters.

"How will this couple handle a year of unexpected misery, caused either by one, both, or neither parties"? Will they talk about it honestly & openly with each other? Do they really listen to each other? Do they speak of each other with tenderness? Do they build each other up?

A serious relationship is a massive undertaking, a heavy burden on your back. It's like lifting weights, actually. You need to have good form. You can tell when someone has bad form, the weight is going to fuck them. But do it well and you get stronger.

Spending a lot of time together doesn't nearly mean as much as people tend to assume it does. Your relationship will die if you *don't* have any quality time together, but simply spending lots of time together doesn't guarantee anything.

Spending a lot of money (that you can afford), going on fancy vacations together, throwing a fancy party (ahem: weddings) all don't mean much. All of those things are actually relatively easy and trivial.

The "killer" signs:

- Contempt. Doesn't matter if you're laughing as you jokingly put each other down. One day it won't be funny.
- Dismissiveness. "Ugh, she's always like that"
- Indifference. "nah it's no big deal, whatever"
- One partner constantly apologizing for the other. This is not sustainable.

This is bad form – when the hard times hit, they'll buckle.

I find that you can often infer quite a bit from a couple's body language and eye contact. A couple that is close will make eye contact often. Not necessarily stare lovingly into each other's eyes (my wife and I actually don't do this much), but just "re-sync" regularly to get frequent snapshots of each other's state.

A sad warning sign: when one person has to constantly apologise for the other. It's usually women apologising for their boyfriends. Don't do it. It rarely gets better. If often gets worse. And y'all often put up with it for years longer than you should. (Let him go, sis!)

You weren't put on this earth to apologise for somebody else! You don't have time for that. It's a full time job apologising for yourself!

^ see, this is a joke that doesn't put anybody down. Anybody who needs to make other people feel weak/small/foolish etc is a red flag.

Also, while being rich won't guarantee relationship success, one of the biggest causes of divorce is financial conflict / debt-related frustration. Getting it right isn't enough, but getting it wrong will cost you.

"Can you explain more about the resentment?"

Sure! Basically, in a marriage, you're going to have to deal with the costs incurred by your partner's mistakes. THEY forgot something, THEY messed something up, you did your part but THEY didn't. This is painful and frustrating.

It will become easy to get angry & frustrated with your partner – especially since you're in such close proximity and your actions impact each other so much. So you need a system to acknowledge, address and resolve all this pain and resentment. In my opinion, this is more intimate than sex.

I'm not saying I'm an expert. I just have some experience to share. Nobody's perfect. But if you want a good shot at making things work you gotta do your due diligence & check in, regularly, even when you're tired, especially when it's hard. It's very easy to overlook this. Acknowledge the mess and work at it.

The Relationship Death Spiral

There's a relationship death spiral that goes like this:

1. You're tired, so you hit snooze on difficult conversations
2. your backlog from 1 is overwhelming
3. You start spacing out in each other's presence (how was your day? fine). You're not really there for each other any more. Life is now just a series of tedious chores you have to do.
4. The "spark" is gone.
5. Since it's all chores and the spark is gone, you're subtly colder and more uncharitable towards each other. You're both play-acting corporate shells at this point and it's very unpleasant.

6. This buildup of resentment and frustration ends up being ignited in a fight over some trivial thing like dishes or laundry. Hint: It's never really about the dishes or the laundry. It's about the relationship.
7. Everything gets worse, and the cycle worsens. The fight leaves you feeling exhausted, which brings us back to 1.

So the meta skill is to recognise that this is a spectrum. There's an Esther Perel quote that goes, "passion waxes and wanes, but erotic couples know how to bring it back". This is likely unique to each couple. But you can see it and you can feel it when you're in the presence of a couple: how open and emotionally intimate people are with each other.

Just to emphasise: we never root for any relationship to fail. Life is hard and love is precious, and we want all of our friends to flourish and be happy. It's just unfortunate that people are so often unprepared for the work. May you all nourish + be nourished in every way. ❤

2. Your spouse will frustrate you more than anybody else

Wife and I were laughing about this last night: the thing nobody quite tells you about marriage is: you're choosing the person in life who's going to upset, disappoint, annoy and frustrate you more than anybody else.

This is true even if your spouse is the least annoying, frustrating, upsetting person you know! Because of base rates. For example, suppose the average person has a 10% chance of annoying me, and my wife has a 1% chance. I still hang with my wife much more than 10x than the average person.

Spouses get to see the worst sides of each other more than anybody else, and so it's very easy for people to learn to think more poorly of their spouses than other people – which is sad because there's a sort of optical illusion / selection bias at

play.

Marriage is the first relationship in your life that's anything like marriage. Nothing quite prepares you for it. When you're dating, you're not yet *entirely* subjected to the consequences of the other person's actions or inaction, and walking away is a cheaper option

Also this probably varies from culture to culture, but other people's assumptions and expectations become a big deal. Families expect things of wives that they don't expect so much of girlfriends. Women often seem to get the short end of the stick on this one.

For us, humor is central to keeping things interesting, fun, compelling. You're not going to escape pain, but if you can laugh about it together (caveat: not contemptuously at each other) then it's still fun.

3. Marriage is hard and requires deliberate project management

On the project management of a marriage, which is something I'm still not very great at + always trying to be better at.
The following is from an impromptu Q&A I did with a researcher friend:

"How do you organize your schedules?"

I'm kind of sloppy about these things. I make plans but I don't always follow them. I tend to plan social meetups on Facebook Messenger, then add them to my Google Calendar once it's confirmed. My workdays are defined by my work tools — Trello, Slack, Google Calendar.

My wife has access to my calendar; she needs to know if I have after-work plans, or weekend plans. We also plan things together sometimes. We figure it out over chat and then we update Gcal accordingly. We also have a personal Slack channel where we go through everything more thoroughly.

"It sounds like you put in quite some effort to sync your schedule with your wife's. is this important to you?"

Well yeah, we have a finite amount of time together, so if we're out of sync it sometimes means someone is left in the dark, unexpectedly alone, lonely without plans.

Once you're married, there's a very large volume of things you have to care about — everything from dental appointments and family obligations (two sets!) to household maintenance. Slack is great for this because you can have multiple channels for each concern and not lose track. But you can use whatever; as long as you have a system that works for both of you. (We were both already using Slack at our respective companies, so it was a small thing to experiment with making our own, for fun. And it turned out great.)

Can you tell me a little more about how planning your everyday life compares before and after marriage?

There's a line from an article that goes, "You'll find yourself wistful for the days when you had to pay for only your own mistakes." It's like that. Each of your mistakes are going to cost both of you now. Sometimes you're going to do (or fail to do) something, and you don't just disappoint or upset yourself — you have to deal with the fact that you upset your spouse. Some people can't deal with this, and get angry at their spouse for being upset. And boom, one of the many spiralling vortexes leading to marital failure.

Before marriage, you are less of a joint unit. Cohabitation is a big part of that — most Singaporeans don't cohabit before marrying. But even if you do

cohabit, after marriage, you each subtly start to feel more obliged to be a bigger part of each other's life. (Of course this varies from couple to couple, some married couples are somehow super independent. I know one married couple that's like long-distance half the time. I don't know how they do it.)

An evil thought that arises after you're married & have your first married fight — you don't HAVE to apologize. You don't HAVE to attempt reconciliation. I mean, you probably will, out of habit, but you could also be like, "fuck it, suffer, I don't care. Whatcha gonna do, divorce me?"

The fact that the cost of walking away becomes so much higher permanently alters the relationship dynamic. The cost/benefit calculus. anybody who says this doesn't affect them at all is either lying or very ignorant (or has attained Enlightenment.)

Their problems are now your problems. There's all this family stuff — which of course varies from couple to couple too. Like, if your parents-in-law are being difficult or something, you can't really be like "Well ok, good luck, not my problem, I'm going bowling with the boys," or whatever. You're obliged to deal.

Once you get married, it's like your relationship is now in a smaller room. It's cosier, but you also can't yell or make as much of a mess as you could before. You could theoretically try, but it almost definitely will hurt the relationship. The skillset that gets you INTO a relationship is very different from the skillset you need to sustain one.

"Would you say that you map out 'unfilled' time with your wife? how do you plan/negotiate that?"

Our default state is a sort of vague coexistence — usually involves both of us hanging out at home and each doing our own thing, me catching up on work or reading/writing. over time we've learnt to be more explicit and deliberate about making requests of each other.

We usually discuss things at a "what needs doing?" level, and then once we've agreed that something needs doing, we put it in a calendar and try to follow it. Keyword: try. Hahaha.

Something we've been trying to be more rigorous about is having explicit time set aside purely for dates or couple time. When you first get married, you're around each other so much and so focused on each other, it feels like you don't have to. But you gotta do it. Very important.

"How does explicit couple time differ from "vague coexistence"? why is planning that so important?"

Right. It's possible to vaguely coexist together for WEEKS, waking up, having lunch together while each of you is on your phone, replying to friends, work emails, having dinner together watching netflix, visiting parents, going thru the motions... and subtly drift out of sync.

By "out of sync", I mean that each of you has a fresh set of concerns and worries that you haven't articulated to your partner yet, because the mere act of articulation is going to be a tedious process.

That's when you start responding to questions like "How was work" with "Eh, the usual" — because you don't want to go through the trouble of explaining what was bothering you. (This is why it's useful to have a #feelings channel in your family slack, so you can just post your feelings as you go... Now that's a life hack!)

Getting "synced up" as a couple is tedious, even when it's with your best friend of 15+ years. You have to negotiate things. You have to talk about feelings, and frustrations. it's always easier to be like "aiya later lah, i'm so tired." You know in advance there'll be disagreement.

"Can you give me an example of friction points and sync difficulty?"

Here's a simple example : let's say we're both frustrated with our shitty old sofa + we both know we want to get rid of it. But talking about it means Having A Conversation. Because we each have different preferences, different styles. I'm happy to toss it + make do. She'd want to review options.

Negotiation is tiring, even when you both know exactly what the other person is going to say — because then you kind of have to do this waltz of feelings and considerations. It requires being alert and aware and sensitive to each other. Otherwise it means being disrespectfully dismissive, and that's the sort of thing that ruins marriages.

So the easy thing for both people to do is to defer the conversation. "Remind me later". That's the 2nd worst outcome, you just quietly get increasingly frustrated with the suboptimal mess you call your lives. The worst outcome is a fight, because one person badly wants to do something and the other really doesn't want to deal with it. How you handle this, while tired af, is the heart of marriage.

& I'm describing one of the simplest, most trivial friction points! Literally Every Imaginable Thing is a potential friction point in a marriage. A sofa is just an object. You're going to be having intense, difficult conversations about much more personal, contentious things. Imagine if you add kids into the picture! So it's insanely important that you both be good at doing this, believe whole-heartedly that you're on the same team, and be kind to each other.

If you don't have a system You Are Fucked. In the absence of a deliberately designed system, lots of families seem to defer to an improvised system of yelling, screaming, guilt-tripping, emotional blackmail… unimaginable cruelty because of a terrible system of management. It's very sad.

There you go, a tiny little taste of what marriage is like. It's really hard, but it's also one of the best things in the world when you get it right. When you're really in sync (or even when you're not, but you trust each other to take care of things), you feel really wholesome, fulfilled, nourished.

PS: Do 1–1's

I wanted to reiterate — a very clever and effective way of dealing with the inevitability of friction points and sync difficulty is to schedule 1–1 meetings in advance. This is an idea I stole shamelessly from work. Basically, have some time set aside (at least once a month) for the EXPLICIT purpose of discussing difficult things. This has several benefits.

1. You don't need to feel bad about interrupting your spouse with what's guaranteed to be a frustrating discussion.
2. It lets you compartmentalize better, so you don't need to be quietly fuming at each other the rest of the time.
3. It also means that when you're having an argument, you can just have the argument and not have a meta-argument about how badly you are having the argument. That meta-argument can be had during the scheduled 1–1s.

It might sound oddly bureaucratic, but if you do it right, it's a huge lifesaver. A lot of couples I talk to tend to get stuck in the meta-argument loop: they have some problem they need to solve, and whenever the argue about it they end up also arguing about how badly they're arguing — and since they're already in a bad mood, they struggle to be receptive to one another. Few issues are perfectly 50/50, so getting into a meta-argument always feels like a derailment of the original issue. AND the original issue never gets resolved.

This is a misery I wouldn't wish on anyone. (And yet it's probably super common in lots of families.) Compartmentalize your arguments, and schedule time to have them in advance so you're not caught off guard. It's also a great excuse to treat yourself to good coffee or beer, and go on long walks, etc.

*4. It is *necessary* to become more considerate as a relationship develops*

The longer a relationship lasts, the likelier it is that you'll step on each other's toes in recognizably repetitive patterns. The longer this goes on, the more hollow of an excuse "I wasn't thinking" becomes. It thus becomes *necessary* to become more considerate.

Here's a maybe-unpopular opinion I have: I think lots of people end their relationships because they lack the will or the ability to modify their own behavior. It is easier to start over with someone else than to do the tedious, uncomfortable work of adjusting for each other.

Of course, this is NOT to say "you should change who you are just to suit your partner" or "you should force yourself to stay in unhappy relationships". Definitely not! That is bad! Rather, I think it's important to be mindful of the patterns of behavior within the context of a relationship.

The pattern I'm describing is:

1. start a relationship
2. enjoy the good times and good vibes
3. accumulate "debt" from bad times and bad vibes
4. fail to address the debt; either avoid it or mishandle it (which makes it worse)
5. be overwhelmed by the scary debt, ditch the whole thing to repeat the pattern with someone else

A lot of pop culture takes on love is all about the good vibes and romantic gestures – about finding a soulmate who "gets you". But even if/when you find that person, you're going to piss each other off! and you have to figure out how to deal with that!

There's of course also a "prisoner's dilemma" aspect to this whole thing. What if you change to be more considerate of your partner, but they don't return the favour? That's an injustice. It's not fair if one person does all the work and the

other person gets to enjoy it for free.

Early on in a relationship, when you're still sussing each other out, this is understandable – and the way forward is to make small changes then look for reciprocity.

In a long-term relationship, if you can't trust your partner… what are you doing? You're very possibly wasting your time. Or your standards are so low that you're willing to tolerate an untrustworthy partner because you're scared of being alone.

Circling back to the start: "I wasn't thinking" is a hollow excuse even if it's true!! I feel like nobody really talked to me about this. A relationship is a commitment to doing the work of becoming a more thoughtful person. You have to think more!! This is challenging!!

Sometimes people ask things like, "aren't you afraid you're going to get bored of each other after a decade?" There are some 🤔 buried assumptions in there. I met my wife in 2000 and honestly she gets more interesting every year. I'd like to think the same is true for me. For the beginner, interestingness is about novelty. For the expert, interestingness is about nuance.

Finally – I think some long-suffering couples solve the "stepping on each other's toes" problem by basically avoiding each other, and keeping to a highly-choreographed routine. To me this sounds like hell, but for some people maybe it's heaven? Do what works for you, I guess.

Anyway, as always, I am not an expert or a counsellor or anything of the sort – just a nerd who overanalyzes everything and has some thoughts and experience to share. May you all nourish and support each other in all the ways you need to be nourished and supported.

5. "Spicing up your relationship" is really about finding ways to be vulnerable with each other.

I have an essay draft making fun of the idea 'how to spice up your relationship' – people think it's about toys and lingerie but it's really about exposing vulnerable bits of your psychology to one another. You can love someone for decades and marry them and still have huge blind spots.

Relationships become boring because they get reduced into shell-scripts, patterns and routines – because people avoid the difficult work of communicating hard, painful things to one another. At this point some people, desperate for stimulation, do crazy shit like cheat.

It's actually entirely possible to have an affair with your own spouse – just literally decide to break from your routine and ask each other questions about things you don't normally talk about, and be honest with each other. Do hard and scary things together.

I think a big reason lots of people fail to do this is because they're shy! You can see your spouse naked, and witness each other throwing up, etc – and yet be too shy to ask each other things that are outside of the stable/familiar configuration you've established together. You're scared that they will judge you for wanting something different, for wanting to be someone different than they've gotten used to.

It's easier to be a different version of yourself with a different person. You can open up your heart completely to a stranger at an airport that you'll never see again, but you might worry about the consequences doing it to someone you have a long-standing relationship with.

So… the challenge is to mitigate the consequences, whether real or perceived. Most people are probably overestimating the negative consequences of talking openly with their partners. But some people might not be. Something to think about.

Flirting and playfulness

I wanted to write a quick bit about flirting, particularly for men.

What I tell my nephews: flirting is basically this – give moderately strong signals of interest with plausible deniability (for you) and outs (for her), and then be attentive for returned signs of interest and riff off of that. If she plays with you, you can ask her out.

It's not actually that complex. I believe that any boy who plays a video game involving stealth where you move a character and the camera at the same time is more than capable of being a skilled flirt. People– boys in particular – just aren't taught how to speak in allusions and innuendos, but it's very trainable. I highly recommend reading books written by women, watching TV shows written by women.

It takes practice. I'm actually liking the video game analogy – there is similarly an algo for "move into space, hide behind cover, anticipate enemy movements, shoot them in the head while paying attention to the entire field of battle" – it just takes practice and you will fail

The trick is to make sure that your failures are survivable. So first identify a list of things you should never do/say (ie blurt out "I love you", "will you be my girlfriend", anything that puts the other person on the spot) and then try a bunch of things other than that

Probably like 9 out of 10 times, you'll end up being too vague or incoherent – but as long as you didn't say anything outright creepy or corner her, you'll be fine and you can live to try again another day. Do this 1000 times and you'll get the hang of it.

--

Something clicked for me when thinking about schools, dance, free speech, attention, attentiveness, flirting...

My #1 piece of advice is "be attentive".

And the #1 shitty response I get to that is "I don't wanna put in all that effort, just give me the formula."

But all of the fun in life - play, conversation, flirting, sex - is what you do when you're playing *with* the rules. But that doesn't mean you *break* the rules. You tease around them. While paying close attention. That's the fun! Oh my god, People don't know how to have fun.

The shadow world of social reality

There is an entire shadow world hiding in plain sight. Learning about this I think was more mind-boggling than learning about the scale and scope of the universe. It's like social dark matter. Most people don't see it and many never will.

This is less "your father is secretly a government spy" and more "most of what you think you know about your father is likely coloured by the father-child

relationship + most people who tell you things about him mostly filter their thoughts with your relationship in mind”.

Consider the following metaphor for subjective social reality: the light in your fridge. Every time I open my fridge, there's light. Therefore, the fridge light is always on.

"My parents are always boring way around me. Therefore my parents are always boring."

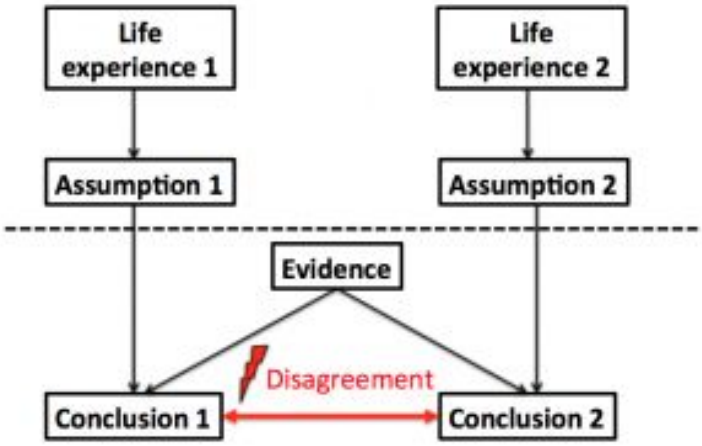
"My male friends are always decent around me. Therefore my male friends are always decent."

A lot of people get very uncomfortable and defensive when you suggest to them that the fridge light is only on when the fridge is open.

"But the light is on EVERY TIME I CHECKED! I check it at different times! I have many data points! My hypothesis has never been falsified!"

As Morgan Housel put it, your personal experiences make up <0.0001% of what’s happened in the world but 80% of how you think the world works. When experiencing a fraction of what’s out there but using that to explain everything you expect to happen, you'll be disappointed & confused by others’ decisions.

Managing disagreements requires context-sensitivity



Disagreements between thoughtful friends who respect each other can lead to everybody doing a whole bunch of reading, learning a lot more about a topic, and coming away feeling closer to each other than before – because they each now see better where the other coming from.

Roughly between ages 13 and 23 I was thoroughly convinced that the best thing an intelligent person could do is to get obsessively good at evaluating and crafting sound arguments. Rationality! Debate! Wisdom!

I rearranged a lot of my life around that wishful ideal: that any obstacle can be solved with a sufficiently sophisticated argument.

The past few years have convinced me that I've been fundamentally mistaken.

Let me try to explain why:

1. **An argument, however sophisticated, is always constructed within some context.** (A therefore B, assuming X, Y and Z...).

2. **The moment you start getting invested in the arguments you're constructing, you begin to get blinded to the world outside of your**

context. It's like how you tune out everything else when you're trying to perform a precise task.

[2b. **If you're earnest, you might try to have a model of not-your-context.** But it's always going to be simplified because of cognitive limitations… as well as some more subtle, insidious reasons. To get a little ahead of myself, every in-group has an oversimplified model of its corresponding out-group. To go a step further- if you MUST argue, it's prudent to start by trying to model your opponent's context, as accurately as possible.]

3. When you get it right, you'll get tremendous validation from other people who share your context. This feels very, very good, and is very, very habit-forming.

[3b. **This is so habit-forming, in fact, I think it's outright addictive.** I think once you get into the habit of fighting for your in-group, you begin subconsciously looking for opportunities to fight for your in-group. There are few drugs as sweet as peer validation. And it's not necessarily a bad thing; a lot of the greatest things about humanity were motivated by peer validation.]

4. **Sometimes you'll win over people who are in adjacent, overlapping contexts – and these few instances are held up as glorious victories.** You will cherish these. But these people were usually more or less already exploring your context to begin with. To put it very crudely, it's like hunting docile rather than wild animals.

5. **Once you start hanging out with people in the same context, there's a sort of natural radicalization that happens.** It's not malicious; it's almost 'physics' – the most attention gets naturally funnelled to the most egregious mistakes made by people outside of the context. So there's a sort of 'gravity' that 'pulls' everyone closer to the 'center'. The most radical members spend the most time in it, influence it the most, etc etc.

6. **Now you have an in-group and an out-group. This is almost always bad news.** The "sound arguments" are now almost entirely subservient to the group needs. The gravity is too strong, it bends the light, and almost nobody realizes this. The people who do realize this will typically be ousted from the group, or quietly leave themselves. More radicalization.

7. **The primary way each group interacts with the other is by focusing on the absolute worst outliers of the other group.** As SMBC said, "every group is some % crazy assholes". Every group in turn holds up the outgroup's crazy asshole as a sort of threatening bogeyman. (Of course, this doesn't mean that all crazy assholes are equally bad or not-bad. Some crazies cause serious harm to other people.)

8. **When a 'normal' member of the group encounters the other group, and gets caricatured as the bogeyman, their response is naturally to get upset.** They might try to argue for a while, but whatever argument they come up with, however sound or calm, can always be framed as "lol why u mad tho". You can't argue your way out of that one, the only way to win is not to play. (Or to win some other game OUTSIDE the narrow context you're currently stuck in).

9. **The vast majority of each group then ends up being highly suspicious of one another.** As a result, they end up barely ever having real conversations with the other. Their contexts are so different that they might as well literally be speaking different languages entirely. (And in fact, if you pay careful attention, they always are. Every in-group develops its own language.)

10. **The only way out of this mess, as far as I can tell, is to avoid labels, avoid in-groups, and to try and make sense of each issue independently.** Don't let your in-group identities precede you. And always be wary whenever you find yourself trying to argue with someone.

11. **The challenge with #10 is to genuinely, legitimately suspend judgement**. You do this by realizing that your judgement is necessarily limited

because it's formulated within a specific context, and that the world is always bigger than your context.

12. **If you're good at doing 10 and 11, you will cease to be surprised or shocked by things like Brexit or Trump or any other supposedly outrageous phenomenon**. The surprise mainly happens because you're heavily invested in your context – the friends you talk to, the media you read, so on and so forth.

13. Let me try to return to the starting point – why I think I'm mistaken. I used to believe that the way to winning people over, to making friends, to earning respect, receiving validation, serving the world, etc – was to get really good at debate, at arguments. The idea there was that if you get good at it, you'll get closer to the truth.

14. **The reality of it, however, is that you get very good at a very narrow subset of things.** You just don't see it because you're so focused on it that the map becomes the territory for you. You become the person who understands the map better than anybody else, but then someday you'll follow your map right off a cliff – because the map isn't the territory, and it can never be.

15. It is much more difficult – and far more useful – to learn to identify the context that you're in, and to ask yourself if that's the context that you actually want to be in. If that's the best context for you.

16. It's exceptionally difficult because it requires relinquishing the validation that you've been conditioned to enjoy from arguing on behalf of your in-group. It requires (at least it did for me) a sort of self-imposed exile. In my experience, this is actually harder than quitting smoking. And it makes sense that it would be.

17. Actually, come to think of it, a lot of the frustration, ennui, listlessness, etc that I've faced in the past 3-4 years has been largely caused by discovering that so much of what I had invested myself into was really some narrow game or other.

Consider, for example, once you're an adult, how silly teenagers seem when they get all caught up in their drama.

18. To the teenagers, of course, it's not silly at all. Their context is all they know. If you mock your child for being frustrated by his "trivial" context (when you're being frustrated by your much larger context), don't be surprised if he decides that you don't understand him. Because you don't.

TL;DR:

Contexts, man. Context is everything. Everybody's is different. Yours will change sooner or later whether you like it or not. When you recognize this, you don't need to argue so much. But of course you can't force this perspective down anybody's throat.

Also – arguments aren't bad things. They're tools. The important thing is to use the right tool for the job.

What makes a disagreement interesting?

The way I see it, often what makes a disagreement interesting is whether or not the other person has a sense of vision. A lot of twitter idiots (from every subculture, tribe, ingroup) have no vision, which makes the disagreements hideously boring – unless you're somehow able to entertain yourself in the process of arguing with idiots.

All communication is lossy and involves trade-offs. A good faith discussion and/or disagreement is sensitive to the fact that the other person has made those trade-offs. "Ha, your communication is lossy!" is so uninspiring. It's the opposite of inspiring; it's dispiriting.

One way to think in terms of makers and critics. You shouldn't have to be a maker to be a critic, but if you're going to be a critic, you ought to be a constructive one. "vision" here is a sense of possibility, an idea of what good would look like. A critic that just goes around saying "this is bad" is worse than useless, he has a chilling effect on makerspace. [Some nitpicking is useful, most of it is trash.]

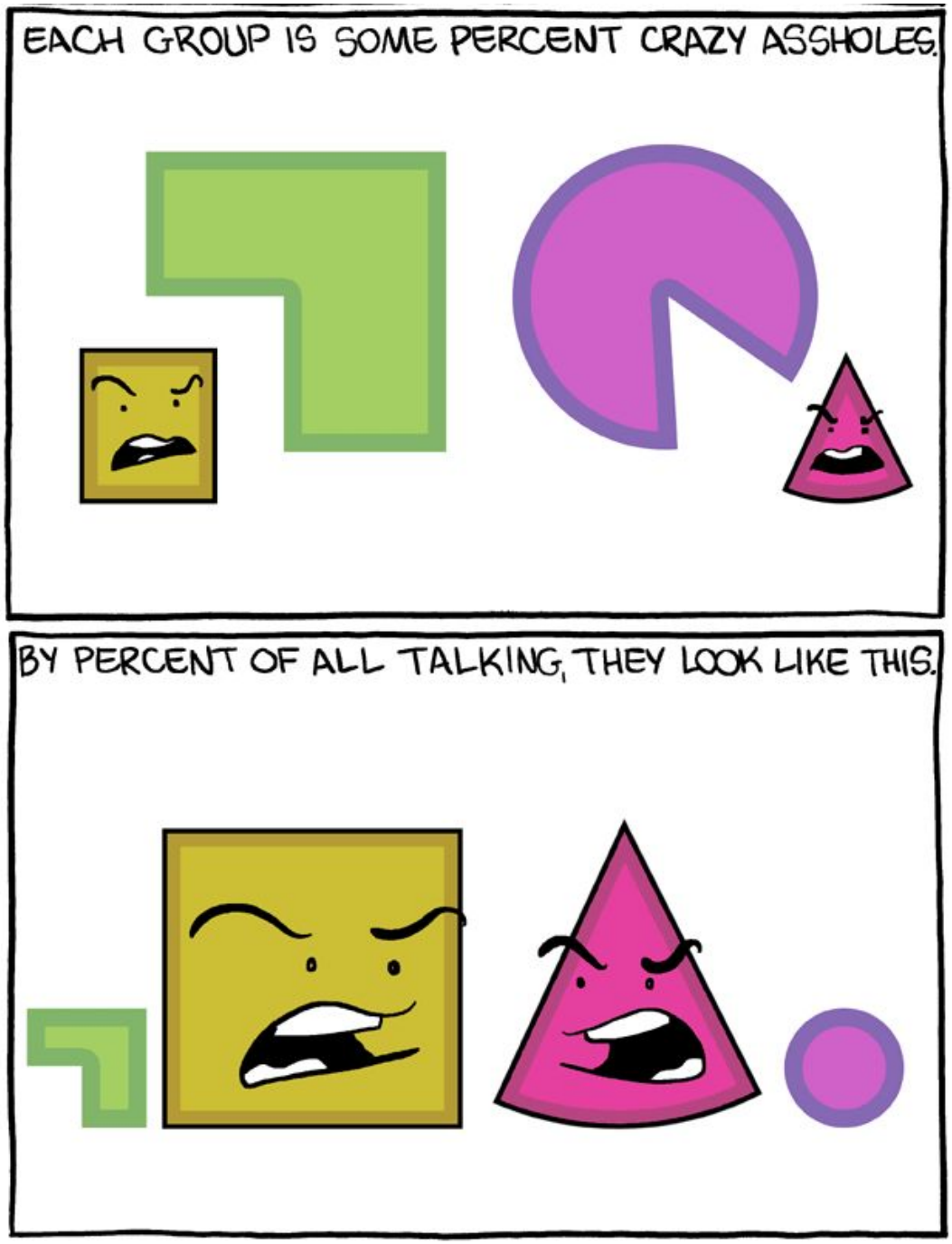
A disagreement is interesting if both parties make an effort to show each other what they each see, and to try and see where the other party is coming from. It's uninteresting if one party is just mindlessly going "boo, no, ew, ick, weak, stupid, bad, fail".

Here's another way of looking at it. If we have a disagreement, we need to identify our respective assumptions, and talk about our respective experiences. If you're not open to doing that, then don't waste people's time by disagreeing with them stupidly!

"But that's so much effort, why should I waste my time doing that?"

Because that's how you *make friends*. That's how you build relationships. That's how you expand your mind. So in my view, you're actually wasting your time if you're not doing that, and instead having shallow disagreements that you don't learn anything from.

Dealing with assholes



How Internet Fighting Works, by SMBC Comics

I think a major theme of my life's work is going to be "how do we coordinate effectively to solve the asshole problem".

Assholes come in all shapes and sizes everywhere – rich, poor, male, female, trans, disabled, white, black, straight, gay… assholes are perhaps the most truly diverse and intersectional demographic.

Mainstream social justice in the early 2010s got contaminated by assholes who were semi-indifferent to justice and hijacked it to pursue their goals of vengeance.

Some assholes are relatively more culpable than others. The cycle of trauma means abusers often turn victims into assholes too, which is something that's difficult to acknowledge and talk about.

Anti-assholes can become even worse assholes than the assholes who made them. They can be weaponized, vengeful asshole vigilantes. I hear about this so often in private, and/but almost never in public. Everyone has an AAA relative or acquaintance.

The reason I think is that average people are scared of confronting assholes, scared of inviting their disproportionate wrath. Assholes can harass and harangue you for hours, days, months, years. Causing you pain, misery and shame is what gets them off.

Because we're so bad and slow at coordinating action with one another (which is, as far as I can tell, a necessary prerequisite for calmly and firmly shutting assholes down), individual assholes are allowed to terrorize & dominate everything from house parties to the White House.

Assholes make up about 1% of most groups, cause about 75% of the damage, and ruin everybody's experience. And we let them, because we still haven't learned to do better.

Dealing with contempt

I've found myself returning to the word "contempt" a lot this year. The word "hate" has gotten diluted ("i hate my husband lol" can be a statement of affection, for example). But *contempt* is something vicious. Contempt is the #1 predictor of divorce.

I think it's very important to be able to discern & identify contempt, because it is noxious & destructive as hell. Contempt isn't mere criticism, or disagreement, or dislike, or distaste. Contempt is wrath. Contempt is a deep, fundamental vicious resentment that borders on murderous.

"I can tolerate anything except intolerance" sounds cute, silly, paradoxical, like a parlor game. "Tolerate anything except contempt" seems like a more intuitive directive to me. Contempt justifies abuse. Contempt is the stepping stone to all kinds of dehumanization.

The devil of course is always in the details, & people will argue over whether some particular statement is contemptuous or not. Hatefuckers who are moderately intelligent are masters at gleefully wrapping up their contempt in plausible deniability, jokes and bad-faith questions.

But we should at least be able to agree on the following premises:

1. Some people are contemptuous towards others.

2. This should not be tolerated.

Some Americans at this point tend to get wrapped up in Free Speech, which is kind of a boring point of contention to me.

From what I understand, #1A means that you can't make *laws* against contempt, because anti-contempt laws will inevitably be abused by federal authorities. That's understandable. But that doesn't mean you should tolerate contempt as private citizens!

Incidentally, there is actually no need to be contemptuous towards contemptuous people. This is a confusing, complicated and emotionally-charged point.

Here's the optimal response to people being contemptuous to you. It's HARD, it's PAINFUL, it's A LOT TO ASK, but it's optimal:

Cold, calm indifference. Dump his ass, cleanly, calmly. No explanation necessary. This is the nuclear option & requires nerves of steel.

Of course, not everybody has this option. Contemptuous, manipulative abusers often design their abuse carefully to make their victims powerless, angry, upset, emotional, overwhelmed, "irrational", etc, then use all of that against them. Hideously cruel.

What are isolated, disenfranchised individuals to do? Build coalitions. You can't act alone against someone who has power over you. You need to find others who can help you. There is a science to calmly ejecting assholes and hatefuckers from communities.

The important thing is to be extremely calm while you do it. They want you to get mad. They want to use your 'overreaction' as fuel to recruit and inspire more

hatefuckers to rally and assemble against you. It's annoying and unfair, but that's the game.

Imagine a cool, collected bouncer, saying "you need to leave" in a neutral but firm voice. Imagine a roomful of people all coordinating that response in reaction to someone who's absolutely losing their shit. That's basically the skillset that we need to collectively develop.

Questions for communities

"What is your personal definition of community?"

My personal approach to thinking about community is to think in terms of behaviors.

Here are some questions that I find useful for making sense of a community, whether we're talking about one that already exists, or one that you're trying to design:

Does the community have a goal, or a set of goals? What are the explicit and implicit goals of the community?

What actions are celebrated, encouraged and incentivized in this community?

What actions are discouraged?

How are these incentives and disincentives applied?

As communities get bigger: what are the means by which all of the above are renegotiated?

Who are the most critical members of the community?

How is status earned within the community?

What is the community's Overton window?

How is conflict resolved within the community between competing perspectives?

Safe spaces are for nurturing, not coddling

I created a "safe space for brown friends" group on Facebook, and I worried that it would end up being an echo chamber. But the folks in there question + doubt + challenge each other a LOT. In fact, they get to do it more effectively when they don't get distracted by noise. Makes me think.

It is my experience that, if you create a "safe space" for a minority group, sparing them the stress of having to explain themselves to clueless outsiders, the level of criticism, argument, discourse, etc inside the group INCREASES. People challenge and spar with each other.

For example, feminists arguing internally about how to best achieve their goals have much more rich, interesting, thought-provoking conversations when they don't have to be interrupted to explain "women are people too" to newbies every 20 minutes.

"If all they do is talk among each other they aren't doing anything really except producing feel good hormones. Glorified tea time small talk." – This would be true IF all they did was talk amongst each other. Which absolutely isn't the case.

In practice, all of the people I associate with live and operate in the real world, and being real experience to the table.

"So what conservatives do all the time?" – This is an extremely unproductive statement that tars an entire outgroup with the same brush + disincentivizes outgroup members from aspiring to be better. If you expect the worst from them, that's what they'll give you.

It's correct that a safe space is limiting- but what people don't seem to realize is that the world outside of it can be even more limiting because of the problem of abuse. Folks understand this intuitively re: children.

It's true that not all outsiders are clueless. The problem is that it only takes 1-5% of clueless outsiders to ruin the experience/atmosphere for everybody. People appreciate this intuitively in the context of house parties, which typically aren't open to public

Re: ideology-specific challenges, I think this is a function of the quality of the people you have in the group. I make it a point to only invite people who are skeptical of being overly ideological. Which is another example of how a limit on one variable can open up discourse

It's also likely true that a lot of safe spaces coddle more than they nourish, but this is a function of how you manage the place rather than anything intrinsic to the place itself

Most brown people I know would much prefer to never have to ever even think about their skin color, let alone talk about it. The problem is that the world will keep reminding you of it, in ugly and painful ways. So it makes sense to get ahead of the issue.

"you are only creating an echo chamber, reinforcing the view of the people there without any counter argument, you are weakening their ability to think outside

the box, you prevent them to face difficulties. Basically you are not creating a safe space, but a more dangerous place." – Again, this mistakenly assumes that everybody inside the box lives there 24/7. Look at me, I'm right here out in the open engaging with strangers. Stepping out for a breather at a noisy party clears your mind and lets you re-engage productively.

If you live in a home with locks on the doors where you don't let strangers in, if you've had private conversations with friends, if you've ever said "let's go somewhere we can talk," then you already intuitively understand the utility of creating a shared private space.

If you use an anonymous account that doesn't have your name or face attached to it, you already intuitively understand the value of a safe space.

If you believe in having restrictions on immigration (I do) then you already intuitively understand the value of a safe space.

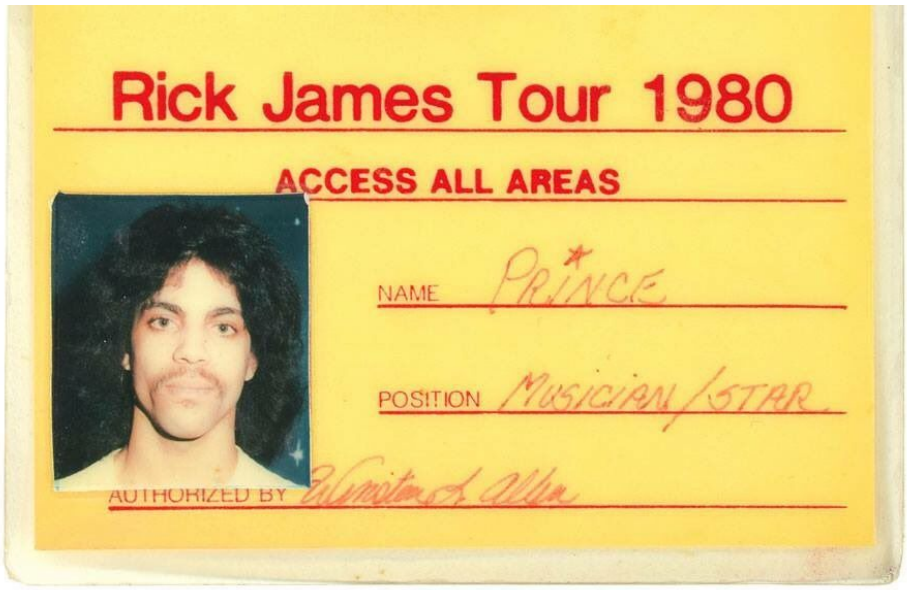
I can also say that in my experience, people who feel nourished and respected inside the group feel supported and energized to go out and have constructive conversations with outsiders in public (as I am doing now).

Of course, creating and maintaining an effective safe space that is nourishing but not coddling is A Lot Of Work.

Ambition

Me at a rock concert, maybe around 2012. I very much wanted to be a rockstar as a teenager. I've since come around to the fact that I don't quite have the perfect cocktail of attributes to succeed at that particular goal, but I do try to bring a little bit of "rockstar energy" to everything else I do.

Ambition is not about accolades



Prince was a classic example of an ambitious person, who had a clear vision of what he was trying to manifest in the world.

I like to dig into the etymology of words. Every word has a history, and each word's meaning is something that changes over time depending on the consensus of the people using it.

According to the Cambridge English Dictionary, the word "ambition" currently means "a strong desire to do or achieve something." The American Merriam-Webster dictionary's top definition is "an ardent desire for rank, fame, or power". There's a slight difference!

Apparently, the concept of "ambition" originated in Roman politics – candidates for public office would have to *go around* to canvas for votes. Words like "ambassador" and "ambulant" have the same root.

When I use the word "ambition" in this book, I'm *not* talking specifically about a naked desire for power or prestige – although it's quite likely that ambitious people *will* accumulate those things. Rather, I'm talking about ambition in terms of things like scale, scope, intensity, perspective.

In my view, artists like Prince, Hendrix and Bowie were ambitious, not because they were trying to sell records or win awards, but because they allowed their taste and sensibility to manifest in their work.

Prestige games contaminate ambition, compress and contain it. Paul Graham had a great bit about it in his essay *How To Do What You Love*:

"Prestige is just fossilized inspiration. If you do anything well enough, you'll make it prestigious. Plenty of things we now consider prestigious were anything but at first. Jazz comes to mind—though almost any established art form would do. So just do what you like, and let prestige take care of itself.

Prestige is especially dangerous to the ambitious. If you want to make ambitious people waste their time on errands, the way to do it is to bait the hook with prestige. That's the recipe for getting people to give talks, write forewords, serve on committees, be department heads, and so on. It might be a good rule simply to avoid any prestigious task. If it didn't suck, they wouldn't have had to make it prestigious."

A fun way of thinking about it might be – what would Prince, Bowie or Hendrix do? Pick your own heroes. There have been people throughout history who marched to the beat of their own drums. They have very distinctive signatures. Richard Feynman was one. David Ogilvy was another. Anais Nin, definitely.

Imagination deficits rule everything around me

A common mistake people make on twitter is reading the dumpster fire junk on the timeline and assuming that that's what they ought to post too. This is a failure of imagination. You should be tweeting what *you* want to see more of. If in doubt, I recommend nerdposting.

Abundance mindset (as opposed to scarcity mindset) is something that makes a very real, consequential impact on a lot of outcomes. I don't know if it can really be as simple as "just act as if you already knew you could do it", but sometimes it actually can be. You could maybe distill this down to "be confident", but I think that phrase is semantically satiated. Maybe "abundance mindset" is, too.

The point is to try and step outside of your existing framework for thinking about how you approach (some set of) things, and to perceive how your past experience and existing worldview influences your expectations of how things will go, and how those expectations would then influence the outcome. It can be helpful to do thought experiments where you "invert" things. How would you think, how would you act, if this came easy to you? If you were good at it? If you knew in advance that you would succeed?

There is a point where this can become *blind* confidence, which is bad. But I think people who struggle with blind confidence are unlikely to be reading this. The important thing to realize is that you're not likely to be at "neutral". There isn't really a neutral at all. **You are likely under-imagining what you can become capable of.** Imagination deficits rule everything around me.

Be so prolific you don't recognize yourself

Comedian Jerry Seinfeld, sitting surrounded by pages of his material.

"To achieve perfection in writing while retaining naturalness, it was important to write a great deal [...] to try over and over again to capture a certain mood, a certain experience. [...] perfection is achieved through repetition." – Anais Nin [source]

Here's a bit from an essay I wrote in 2014, Letter To A Young Songwriter:

Strive to be prolific.

Notice I didn't say 'aim to be great,' or 'just have fun'. Both of those are stupid directives, because they're overly vague. And trust me, the two most frustrating things you can get caught up in are "Will I be great? Am I good enough?" and

"Am I having fun?" You have a far greater shot at tasting greatness and fun if you simply write as much as you possibly can, and then some.

You might think that you ought to try to write the best song that you possibly can, but you'd be wrong. That's actually a trap that you should try your hardest to avoid, especially when you're just starting out.

Why? Because your concept of 'best' is a work-in-progress and a moving target. Why spend a year working on writing the best song you can, when you could instead spend a year improving your idea of what makes a song great?

You don't actually know what makes a good song, you don't actually know what matters to you, you don't actually know what you ought to be writing about. (Some veterans will tell you that they don't know either, but at least they know that they don't know, and songwriting is their way of figuring that stuff out.)

So don't worry about any of that. Just write hundreds of songs.

Always be seeking new friends

If this is a post about friends, why is this being put under the Ambition topic? Because... seeking new friends is an ambitious thing to do!

One of my core insights that people on Twitter seem to love is as simple as this: the social reality you inherited is not necessarily the one you must inhabit for the rest of your life. There are literally billions of people in the world, and you've probably met less than 20,000 of them. Lots of people's intuitions are calibrated for this 20,000-person universe. But you don't actually live in 20,000-person universe, you live in a 7,500,000,000+ person universe.

I get that this can seem kind of... transactional. But I am categorically *not* talking about being some sort of low-effort spammer. I *loathe* those guys. You can find

multiple tweets from me over the years along the lines of, "spam is a plague on all our houses", and "bad actors are insufficiently penalized for the consequences of their actions".

I believe that you can meet effectively anybody in the world if you have internet access and you're willing to spend 10 years working on it.

This is basically the final form of advanced reply guy methodology. To meet any person, find out what they want, and make it. If the person has a gated network, find out what their gatekeepers want, and make it. People will trip over themselves to refer you if you're legit.

Optimize for referrals – rather than try to meet 100 new people blind, meet the 100 or so people you already know, identify the best 5-10 of them (whatever that means to you), and then develop yourself so those people refer you to their friends.

There is more intelligence outside of your head that inside your head, and having smart friends accelerates your intelligence development.

The more interesting question to ask, compared to "how do you compete with smarter people", is "how do you win the love, trust, support & goodwill of smarter people, so that THEY are on YOUR side?" It's interesting how rarely anybody seems to ask this. I think about this all the time.

You can’t think your way out of a courage deficit

Courage is a concept that I don’t think I properly appreciated until my twenties. I mean, yeah, you see it in the movies and hear about it in the stories. Courage is about facing up to your fears.

You can’t think your way out of a courage deficit. Thinking can help, but only to the degree that it gets you to act. Thinking can also lead you to think that you need to do more thinking. In this regard you can totally have a thinking addiction, and once you look out for it you start noticing problem thinkers everywhere

The challenging thing is that you can get addicted to intermediate steps that are genuinely helpful, eg part of my picky eater journey meant that I was watching a bunch of videos about food preparation, I could’ve ended up just watching videos for years .

The important thing is to take the next step.

Be wary of hotheads

When I was in basic training, one of my NCOs told me - when introducing guys to firearms and grenades, you wanna watch out for two groups: the overly enthusiastic hotheads, and the really morose/disengaged. Nervous guys are fine, it's normal to be nervous.

Somehow I got reminded of this while thinking about ambition and ambitious people. I love it when my kind, nervous, self-critical friends have ambition, and I try to nurture and support that as much as I can. But NotAllAmbition; hothead ambition is something I'm wary of.

Friend: I'm currently helping 5 people and I wonder if I could scale up and do more? But I'm afraid I might, idk, lose sense of proportion? What if having more power & influence corrupts me somehow

Me: that fear and doubt is exactly what will make you a great leader! ❤️💪🏾🔥

Another friend: I'm going to be a fucking millionaire in 3 years, watch me

me: ah... u ok tho? who hurt you

I'm not saying that pursuing wealth or glory or power or influence is intrinsically bad; I don't think that's true. It's not intrinsically good either. It's how/why you do it that matters in my book.

Nerd

Me reading a book, aged 9.

Consider our nerdy predecessors

I get a lot of mileage personally from reflecting on the fact that there have always been nerds in the world. Archimedes supposedly said “don’t disturb my circles” before he was killed by a Roman soldier.

One of the things about being a friendly ambitious nerd, when you’re just starting out, is that you might find that there aren’t very many people like you around. But if you look to history, you’ll find that there have always been people like us. People who want to find things out, for the joy of it.

It’s a blessed thing, I think. To realize that you’re never just some isolated weirdo – you’re participating in a grand tradition. There might be no other nerds in your vicinity, but the nerds from the past and future smile upon you.

I was raised by libraries

Reflecting this morning on how my starting conditions were a lot more hostile, cold, abrasive and distant than I choose to remember. I think it's actually quite remarkable that I'm not much more of an asshole; all credit for that goes to the libraries & storytellers who raised me

I do not credit my family. I do not credit my schools, except for some individual teachers. I do not credit my meatspace community. Credit for my early friends is complicated, because we were drawn to each other and we hurt each other with the behavior we inherited

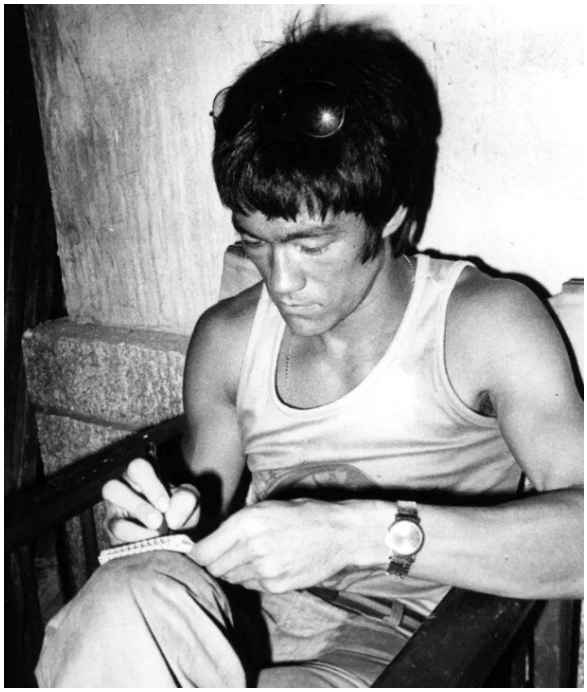
In several ways + at several scales, I was born at the tail end of multiple threads of traumas. So my personal demons are less horrifying than my predecessors. When your grandparents' generation lived through literal war & occupation, what are your problems? Quaint, in comparison.

But trauma, if it isn't transmuted, perpetuates. It passes on from parent to child, in a caustic cycle of ignorance and fear. The world babies and bullshits us when we are children; not only is Santa a lie, so is the illusion of justice and fairness and kindred institutions.

One of my favourite stories I saw on reddit was a parent who taught her child that the secret of Santa is that YOU get to be Santa, and you get to join the secret group of people who make the world a better place for other people. I find that very compelling and heartwarming

May we all heal ourselves, and each other, with love and laughter. We're only here for a little while.

Take notes



Bruce Lee took notes. All the cool kids did.

Hypothesis: if you do barely anything with your life but take little notes every day, journal, diary, whatever – snapshots of your opinions, impressions, perspectives, predictions – and then you thread these notes over time, say, 10 years…

…by the end of it, if you reflect, review, corroborate, verify and discuss them with others, you will have an incredibly robust… mind? worldview? You will deeply

appreciate the nature of human reality in a way that you cannot get from any single book or person or experience.

The thing about the ongoing process of journaling that you cannot get from reading a book,is – your own relationship with your own writing changes over time. you read things you wrote that you thought were smart last year, but look stupid to you now. and vice versa.

Should everybody journal? I don't know. I do think that most of us are kind of journaling anyway via our participation on the web. We journal with search queries and likes and favourites and clicks and so on.

But this information is very poorly packaged for the user – fragmented and sometimes outright inaccessible. So it's kind of like we're journaling for our corporate masters more than for ourselves 😅

So in a way journaling for yourself is a radical act! It's an act of self-ownership, self-education. It's about setting your own curriculum, defining your own worldview, deciding for yourself what is important. I don't think this should be outsourced to others, but that's my POV.

If you're like me, keep meticulous notes of whatever you do when you're procrastinating. I think of it as "deep-self-directed work". If you're going to watch trashy movies then write down your thoughts after watching each movie. It'll come in handy in ways you least expect.

Cultivate and gratify your taste

This is a picture of Paula Scher, a highly-accomplished graphic designer and typographer. There's a Netflix episode about her in Abstract: The Art Of Design. I highly recommend it. She just "gets it".

I saw someone tweet "I wish smart writing came to me as easily as dumb tweeting" and I am here to share with you my strategy for using the latter to precipitate the former.

The first rule of smart writing is you must recognise what smart writing is. Sounds simple enough but most people fail at this. Lots of smart writers get their good quotes ignored and their tepid quotes celebrated. This lowers everybody's standards. Orwell warned about this.

If you want to write well, I think you may need to spend more time identifying good writing than actually writing. You need to develop your aesthetic taste re: what good *is*. No one else can do this for you.

Now – the next thing you need to know is that *trying* to make smart writing is often counter-productive. There's probably a simple reason for this. Smart writing often happens by accident when you accidentally take clever shortcuts when you're focused on getting from A to B. [list of examples]

Once you know what smart writing looks like, forget about it. Forget about trying to look or sound smart. It rarely happens when you want to. It happens peripherally when you're trying very hard to communicate something else.

Which brings us to dumb tweeting! All you have to do is to follow your nose (which hopefully has been honed over time from evaluating everything that comes your way). There's almost always something interesting about everything if you find the right angle on it.

The cool thing is, you don't actually need to find the smart angle! Writing is cheap, basically free. Write all the angles. Whatever comes to mind, whatever tickles your fancy. Write stupid, edit smart. By using your own taste to retrospectively identify what's good.

Crucially- your concept of smart is very much informed by everything you've already read. If you're trying too hard to be smart, you will mostly just remix what you've already read. You have to leave the comfort of smart & enter the frontiers of dumb to create *new* smart things.

(I am deliberately using the words "smart" and "dumb" here slightly differently than in common parlance. "Dumb" as in "dumb question, but…", and "smart" as implied by "prestigious". See Paul Graham's essay How To Do What You Love, which talks about prestige.)

Ask dumb questions earnestly and chase down all the implications even if it feels stupid.

Disregard the impulse to *appear* smart by writing in clichéd tropes that signal status and authority.

Everything we retroactively consider genius started out this way!

If subsequently you want to dress up your ideas in smart language, go ahead. Sometimes you need to use the king's language to argue with the king. But beware falling into the trap of thinking that it's the king's language that makes him smart, or that he's smart because he's king.

If you're moderately intelligent and have moderately decent taste, producing a stupidly large quantity of work and applying a modicum of taste when reviewing and editing it will precipitate smart writing. Because you are smarter than you know, or even dare to believe.

You can end up producing smart work *entirely* by accident, and still own it because you recognized it. It's yours! That's the gift that the creative process just gives you sometimes. You can then study and reverse-engineer this, and wow, you just got smarter as a result.

1. Develop your taste
2. Produce a large volume of work, non-judgmentally, with the intent of having fun and pursuing your curiosity rather than trying to be smart
3. Edit 2 based on 1
4. Congrats, now people think you're smart
5. Don't let 4 get to your head!! Repeat 1-2-3

The public is generally really bad at dealing with people who make good work. They pedestalize them, worship them, or demonize them – everything short of engaging thoughtfully with the work. Which brings us back to… the public is insufficiently educated on how to be a good public.

Don't worship people. You're doing them a disservice, and you're insulting + hamstringing the process that makes good work. If you *have* to worship something, worship the process.

When you worship your heroes, you distract them from the process that enables them to make great work. Encourage the process, participate in the process. They're people too. Every creative mind is always yearning for more good minds to play with.

FAQs about taste

"How do I develop taste?"

Well it shouldn't be something you force yourself to do. What do you already like? What are you already interested in? Explore that with a playful curiosity and ask yourself what's good, what's not good. Have fun!

"How do I produce a large body of work?"

A house is built one brick at a time. Make a brick. Then make another brick. Then another. The secret is that you forget worrying about the house and enjoy making bricks. It's fun because you get to exercise and develop your taste.

"I want to produce work but something is stopping me."

It's usually some form of fear or perfectionism. Your technical skill is not yet good enough to gratify your taste. Let go of the expectation that you have to gratify your taste *today* (or *ever*). Make Crappy Stuff!!

"I've made a bunch of stuff but I still suck."

This is a feature, not a bug. Welcome to the creative life! Everybody struggled with this. It's what made them good. Keep making more stuff. When in doubt, make more stuff.

"My stuff has gotten predictable and formulaic and I hate it."

Good! Discard it all! It's all tracings in the sand anyway. Find a new game! Watch different movies, travel somewhere different. Find new things and make new things. You have my permission to start all over again.

"My friends laugh at me and insult my work."

Fuck them. Find new friends. Life is too short to be around people who belittle you needlessly. You can find friends who will offer thoughtful feedback instead.

"Nothing I do is original."

Nothing is! Renaissance paintings are bible fanart. The bible itself was probably compiled and remixed from existing stories. Everything has predecessors, everything is a remix. You can't make original things. But you can make interesting things. The iPhone was a remix of the Walkman and the Polaroid. Everything is a remix of other things. Creativity is connecting dots. Find interesting dots and play around with interesting connections.

"I'm afraid of being judged."

Separate the creator-you from your personal identity. You are just the janitor, the custodian of the subconscious genie inside you. You deserve neither credit nor blame for the quality of the work. Your job is just to show up.

"This isn't fun."

Then ditch it! I feel like it bears repeating that at the heart of all of this is a sincere love for whatever you're playing with. If you don't love the work (movies, tweets, whatever) then everything downstream is going to seem off, and you might waste years trying to fix the wrong problem.

–

So far I've talked about all of this at the individual level. It gets cooler: A lot of the fun of making stuff is playing with other people. A lot of my personal favorite tweets were written in response to friends mucking around.

Nobody gives a shit about my best tweets except me and a small handful of close friends. But that's fine!! If I can only satisfy one person in the world with my work, it has to be me. Never be so busy trying to please other people that you forget to gratify yourself. You are the most important person to please with your own work. [Relevant Ray Bradbury quote]

Be Precise

"Everything is vague to a degree you do not realize till you have tried to make it precise, and everything precise is so remote from everything that we normally think, that you cannot for a moment suppose that is what we really mean when we say what we think." - Bertrand Russell

My ex-boss Dinesh introduced me to the above quote. He told me that it was a quote that totally changed his life. I'm not sure if I ever quite appreciated it as profoundly as he does, but I have to say that it changed my life, too.

The fundamental idea is pretty simple. We tend to think and talk in vague terms. We think and say things like, "I want to be successful". But what does that mean?

How do you know when you've succeeded at being successful? If you're not precise about where you want to go, you're unlikely to get there.

Another way of thinking about this might be: nobody gets to the top of a mountain by accident. You have to decide precisely that that's where you want to go (the top). And then you have to make a plan. You have to do your preparation and training, because otherwise you're going to find that you get exhausted halfway on your way up. Or worse, you might go to the top and find yourself unable to come down. People do actually die when mountaineering.

That got a little more morbid than I intended. The point is, if you challenge yourself to be precise in your language, and precise in your thinking, you will find yourself becoming increasingly effective as an individual. You start achieving your goals more, you start seeing things more clearly. Precision is a bit costly in the sense that it takes effort, but the effort pays off in spades.

How I deal with my ADHD

Kids in my DMs with ADHD symptoms are always surprised when I tell them that I don't think they should try to suppress their mind's wild swings. My advice is to develop the practice of taking meticulous notes instead. It worked for many prolific individuals throughout history.

To have ADHD, in my view, is to be blessed & cursed to be the custodian of a wild trickster spirit who refuses to be tamed, broken, refuses to obey anybody else's directions – including your own. You can't win, so you might as well accept your fate and go along for the ride.

Which isn't to say that you don't have to care about your worldly responsibilities. you do. That's the curse part. The trickster doesn't cooperate, or live on your

schedule, but you have to clean up their messes. Accepting this can be painful, but that's what growing up is.

But if you take care of your shit, if you don't get grumpy and upset and grovel, if you don't resent the wild child inside you – then you get to experience the blessing. and the blessing is that they will lead you on the grandest adventures that other people can't even imagine.

Don't beat yourself up, don't thrash about – that'll likely make it worse. Try to relax. try to believe. You might be different from all your peers, but you are not alone. you are not broken or spoiled. Others have been on this journey before, and they are some of humanity's best.

–

I’ve basically taught myself to manage my ADHD with notes and threads. My “schedule intelligence” (deadlines, calendars, checklist) is terrible but my recognition and web-jumping is fantastic, so I spent something like a decade using the latter to build an elaborate mind-palace

If you’re like me, keep meticulous notes of whatever you do when you’re procrastinating. I think of it as “deep-self-directed work”. If you’re going to watch trashy movies then write down your thoughts after watching each movie. It’ll come in handy in ways you least expect

To me, the most critical part of becoming “so good they can’t ignore you” is to be “so prolific you don’t recognise yourself”. Once you cross that threshold you can actually look at your own work with a relatively objective, critical eye.

People are sometimes surprised to hear how agnostic and indifferent I am to specific methods, formats, tools. The only thing that really matters to me is a sense of flow and throughput through the entire pipeline.

Getting lost is a feature not a bug, the only real problem is getting jammed.

Here's a quick sketch of my personal (ideal) style:

Move fast, hit hard, wipe quick and move on to the next thing, but be micro-rigorous in making sure that each new thing quickly considers all past things, and is threaded accordingly.

my biggest weakness at the moment is actually "wipe quick" – I sit with half-done things for too long, but the real problem isn't that they're half-done, but that they're not properly threaded.

Properly-threaded half-dones are *fine*. Lingering on a half-done for too long is not. By "properly threaded" I mean contextualized against everything else that I'm doing, plotted on the map of my body of work.

All of life is a set of projects, run in elaborate configurations of both series & parallel. There are many ways to play it. Loosely it seems like the smart thing to do is to increase your output (empower yourself) & reduce net resistance (unshackle yourself), so you can do more.

There IS a situation where increasing output or reducing resistance might not be the smart thing to do – it's when you're using that additional net power to do things you don't actually want to do. climbing the wrong trees, doing more projects that don't actually serve you.

(But usually that increased capacity / reduced resistance is something that serves you long term, so if you got stronger in order to achieve X, and X is stupid, you can still use your newfound strength to then achieve Y, which might be less stupid. Don't overthink this.)

Shower thought: what's the single most important project in my life right now? and what came to mind was "unshackling myself further". What are the current shackles, & how do I break them? & what will I do after?

Classes of shackles:

- limiting beliefs & assumptions
- meatbag status (health)
- outdated habits & coping mechanisms
- immediate environment
- peer group
- financial situation
- information diet
- social reality

they're all connected, which is why they're hard to break.

Some parts of social reality are very hard to escape. For example, as long as I'm a male Singaporean citizen, every year or so I have to put on my army uniform and go for military reservist training for a week or two. Trying to break this shackle is super costly; it’s better to simply cope.

On the other hand, limiting beliefs are sometimes shackles that you can shake off just by finding out what they are. Sometimes they wither away upon contact with awareness. Sometimes they reveal themselves to be malignant and persistent, and may require invasive psycho-surgery.

Pay It Forward

When I was a broke teenager, my older friends often insisted on paying for drinks or meals. I used to feel a potent mix of gratitude and shame at this. I deeply appreciated the help, but I often also felt embarrassed, like I was a helpless "charity case".

A few years later, I got a job that paid better than I dared to believe I was worth at the time. So I found myself in the privileged position of being able to treat others in turn. And then it all clicked for me. It's the circle of life! Why didn't any of my older friends point this out to me? (Well… perhaps they did, and I was too busy grovelling to notice.)

Anyway – so these days, when I get the opportunity to treat younger or less privileged friends, I don't say, "Don't worry about it, it's on me." Because I clearly remember how I still felt guilty when my friends said that, even though I know that they meant it with absolute sincerity and kindness.

Instead I say, "My mentors treated me, so now I'm treating you – and I'm counting on you to treat the next kid." I love noticing how their eyes light up at this. Because now they're no longer merely a recipient of charity. Now they are part of something much bigger than either of us, and they have an opportunity to keep something going.

Isn't it one of the coolest stories to hear about how people sometimes offer to pay for the groceries of the next person in line, and then that person does the same, and it goes on and on? Technically speaking, it's not a particularly "big deal". It's typically a small-ish amount of money. Yet there's something very life-affirming about these stories, isn't there? One lady described feeling euphoric at having started such a chain. And I think I relate to that feeling: it makes the world seem like a slightly less lonely place.

So if you ever find yourself thinking, “I don’t know how to accept this much love,” the answer is to pass it on!

If you were raised in a tough environment, if you’ve been lonely and isolated for most of your life, suddenly receiving a lot of love can be quite a shock to the system. You might find yourself subconsciously resisting it, because it seems so foreign. What’s the catch? You’ve never received nice things before, so what’s happening here?

This tweet from @sehurlburt changed my life. Why was I sitting around feeling incapacitated by guilt when there are others who feel entitled to openly just ask for free stuff?

Something else that I didn’t fully appreciate when I was younger: When people help you from a place of sincere kindness, in a way that brings them joy to help you, it can actually be kind of you in turn to let them! If you sense that it’s genuine, don’t resist it. Pay it forward.

I’ve also found it really heartening to use this frame when people gush at me with admiration. Sometimes I get people on Twitter saying things to me like, “I can’t thank you enough, you’ve changed my life.” It’s tempting for me to think, “Hah, I’m so great.” And it’s tempting to simply say, “You’re very welcome,” and leave it at that. Which is a valid response, of course. But the coolest thing to say is, you guessed it: “Pass it on! 🥰”

It's how I choose to interact with my own heroes, too. Rather than gush at them excessively (which then becomes something that they have to manage), I thank them as calmly as I can, and let them know that their work has passed through me and is now helping other people in turn. The responses are always wonderful as well. Some of my heroes are now my friends because of this.

People love to feel appreciated. People love to feel like they made a difference. People love to feel like they're a part of something bigger than themselves.

Pass it on.

Closing thoughts

I'm writing this at 10:13pm, several hours before this ebook is scheduled to be published (at 4am Singapore time).

To be perfectly honest, I don't think I spent enough time on this book. And maybe that's how I'll always feel about everything that I publish and share with the world.

I believe that a cool thing about this ebook format is that I should be able to ship subsequent versions. So this is the v1.0 closing statement. I can already think of some edits that I ought to be doing. But… hey, that's life.

There's a lot of stuff that I wanted to include in this book that I wasn't able to, partially because of time constraints, partially because of the frame of the book itself, and partially because I haven't yet become as skilled of a writer as I'd like to be.

I hope you will forgive me for any sloppiness and imperfections that you've found above (please feel free to tell me about them!), and I'll correct them as soon as I can. If you have any criticisms of the writing itself, if you think any of my ideas are wrong or misplaced, or if you find large chunks of it tedious and boring – I'd love to hear from you. You'd be doing me a tremendous service.

Thank you so much for reading.

Acknowledgements

My parents, for encouraging my reading habit, and for being readers themselves.

Sharan, my wife, for being my best friend. You have endured so much of the worst of me, and you're still by my side. I'm even more excited for our future together than I was when we first met. I'll resubscribe to you every time.

Dinesh, my ex-boss, for being a real mentor, for seeing potential in me when I was beginning to question myself, and for challenging me to be better than I was.

My friends, both online and IRL, for encouraging and supporting me. Y'all know who you are.

You, the reader, for caring, and for supporting me on my writing journey. I hope you found something in this book that you can take with you and use in your life.